

2. AMULETS OF THE INCANTATION OF WISH FULFILLMENT

In April 1944, archeologists Feng Hanji and Yang Yourun excavated a small Tang-era tomb on the campus of Sichuan University, in Chengdu. The simple single-chamber tomb, located near a bend in the Jin River, contained one occupant, whose head was oriented toward the southwest (figure 2.1). Along with a number of other objects placed carefully around it, including urns, dishes, and bowls, and along with coins placed in its mouth and hands, and a jade slip in each hand, the skeleton bore a silver armlet on its upper right arm. Its beauty and workmanship aside, the armlet did not especially attract the attention of the archeologists. Later, however, during the work of cleaning and conserving it, sections of the badly oxidized ring came apart in the hands of one of the scholars, who then made a momentous discovery. Inside the ring, folded and tightly rolled, was a sheet of paper, roughly square at 31 by 34 centimeters, with a text in Indic characters printed in a spiraling square formation around an image of a multiarmed bodhisattva figure. Images of Buddhist ritual implements adorned its outer rim—hand mudras and objects wreathed in flame and buddhas encircled by haloes of light. On the right side of the sheet was a colophon in Chinese, badly damaged and difficult to read, but with the words Chengdu, “Dragon Pool Workshop” (*longchi fang*),¹ and “spell text printed for sale” (*yinmai zhouben*) legible enough.² The paper, according to the archeologist who wrote the report, was exceedingly thin, nearly transparent, yet still possessed of remarkable tensile strength. This, he notes, was characteristic of the silkworm cocoon paper (*jianzhi*) of the Tang period, a paper made from the mixture of silkworm cocoons, mulberry bark, sesame, and sandalwood that shone in the glare of the sun.³

The colophon did not identify the Sanskrit text printed to its left, but though this was (as far as I can determine) the first such sheet ever discovered in a tomb or in an armlet—or in any other context of actual use—other similar

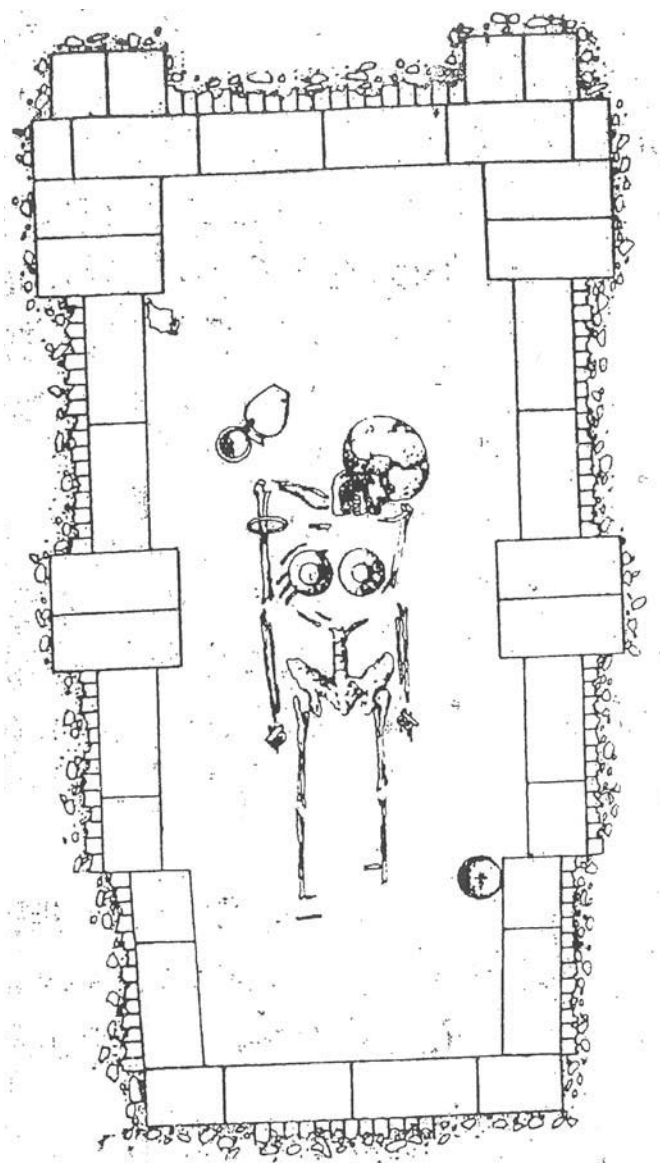


FIGURE 2.1

Drawing of anonymous Tang-era tomb, Sichuan. After Feng, "Ji Tang yinben tuoluoni," 70.

xylographs, bearing labeled Sanskrit texts of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*, had been discovered far to the north of Chengdu, in the cache of manuscripts and paintings in one of the Mogao caves near Dunhuang, nearly a half-century earlier. Feng Hanji, in his account of the amulet's discovery, makes clear that these earlier finds, particularly the incantation xylograph known today as Stein Painting 249 (figure 2.2), were crucial in identifying the Chengdu example.⁴ Indeed, the Chengdu armlet and its contents have in turn proved just as important for the ways they help to complete our understanding of the Dunhuang finds, the sutra, and the larger practical traditions both related to. Stein Painting 249, a dazzlingly elaborate printed sheet dated 980, quotes a scriptural passage describing its intended use and the modes of its efficacy.

The *Great Dhāraṇī of Wish Fulfillment*. If one practices⁵ this spirit-incantation, one's position will be victorious. If there is one who can copy it out and carry it on his head or on his arm, he can complete all the meritorious acts of utmost purity. He will ever be held in the protective embrace of gods and dragon kings and will be remembered and kept in mind by all buddhas and bodhisattvas. This spirit-incantation can bestow the utmost security and bliss upon all beings. They will not be bothered or attacked by yakṣas, rakṣas, or any other demons or spirits. Neither can loathsome *gu*-sorcery or spells or curses harm him. Practicing [this spirit-incantation] eliminates disasters from the sins of past acts. The one who wields this incantation will ever be secure and blissful; will be without sickness; will be brilliant and full in form; will be perfect in his auspiciousness. His blessings and virtues will increase. All his spell arts will be successful. If one practices [this spirit-incantation], and makes offerings to it, one will be fit for protection and purification.

This text, which squarely places the sheets in a trans-Asian culture of Buddhist amuletic practice, is a slightly modified passage from a Chinese translation of the *Mahāpratisarā dhāraṇī sūtra*, a title its earliest and most widely influential Chinese rendering translates as *Foshuo suiqiu jide dazizai tuoluoni shenzhou jing*, or *The Scripture of the Dhāraṇī Spirit-Spell of Great Sovereignty, Preached by the Buddha, Whereby One Immediately Attains What Is Sought*.⁶ This scripture was an important feature in the amulet practice instantiated within the Chengdu tomb, both as one vector of its transmission in China and as the prescriptive anchor for at least some of its practitioners (though, as I will explore later, this last point is not as clear as one might expect). *Pratisara*, the Sanskrit word that lies at the heart of the title (and its practical tradition), means most basically

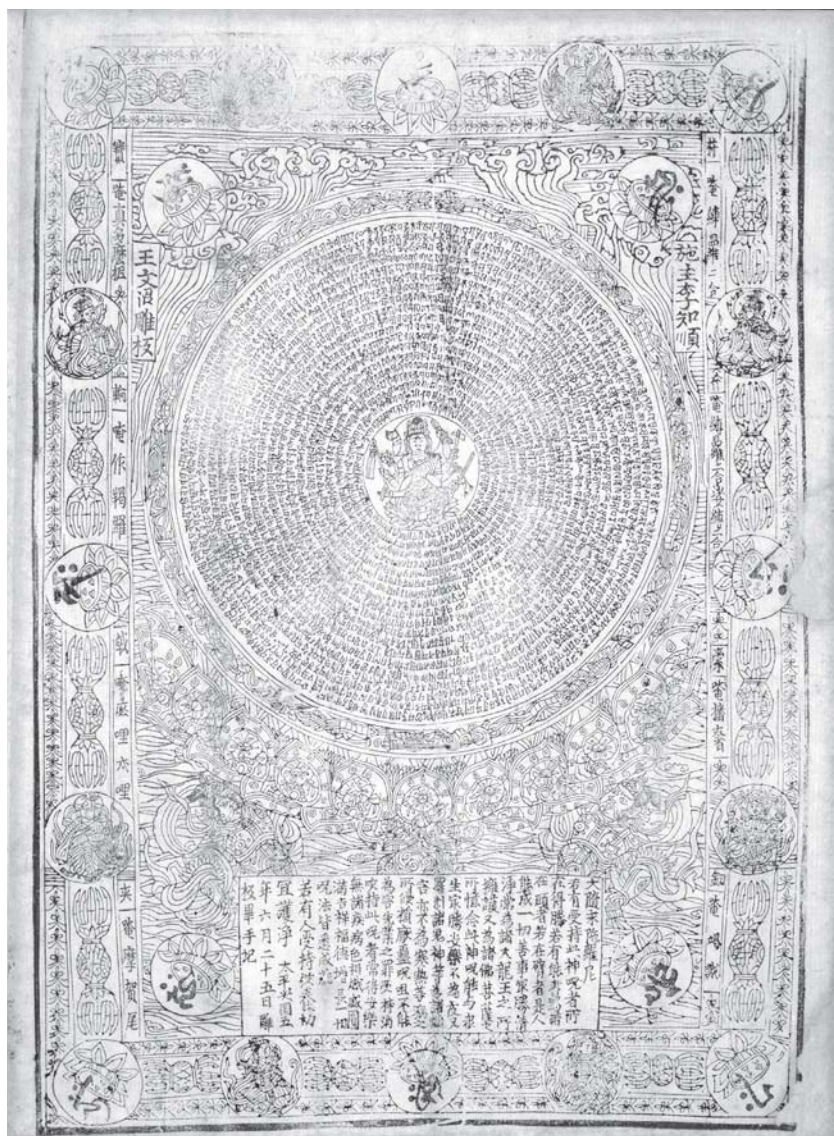


FIGURE 2.2

Li Zhishun Mahāpratisarā amulet [“Mahapratisara Bodhisattva with text of *Da sui qiu tuoluoni*”]. Stein Painting 249 (Ch.xliii.004). Xylograph, ink, and colors on paper. 41.7 × 30.3 cm. © The Trustees of the British Museum.

a “circle,” or “garland,” and was the name for “a cord or ribbon used as an amulet worn round the neck or wrist at nuptials, etc.”; for “the dressing and anointing of a wound”; and for spoken charms of protection.⁷ One scholar has suggested that the term’s basic sense of “circle” gave *pratisara* amulets a sense of “counter-magic,” of returning violence back upon its sender.⁸ Thus, the Sanskrit name for the incantation means something like “the Great Bracelet,” or the “Great Amulet,” senses that, as we will see, though they were invisible within the Chinese translations, had very literal referents in the practices in which the spell was enacted (a fact that hints at the very different levels at which medieval Chinese Buddhists engaged the imported tradition).⁹

In medieval China, the *Scripture*’s injunction that its spell should be carried “on one’s arm” (it makes no special reference to bracelets or pendants) might normally be taken simply as one among countless ritual imperatives, the popularity of whose actual practice remains unknown. Yet after 1944 it took on new, even singular, importance, as did the text as a whole. For in that small anonymous tomb by the bank of the Jin River lay a figure actually wearing it on his arm.¹⁰ The silver armlet, along with other similar carrying cases that would be found in later years, provides something we only very rarely have: evidence that the small ritual prescriptions of the sutras were actually carried out in the late medieval period; even better, it shows precisely how they, or at least this one, were carried out. The armlet, and others like it, as well as what appear to have been necklaces or pendants, and the amulet sheets within them, suggest a complex history of religious practice in which scriptures and their accounts were not fully normative, were not the primary sources for the traditions they were parts of. The conventions of the wider trans-Asian Buddhist amulet traditions, along with local contingencies of economics, craft traditions, and human desire, seem—unsurprisingly—to have played at least as prominent a role as did the scriptural texts and their quoted fragments. But though we must dislodge them from any uniquely central place in the tradition, normative scriptures did, naturally, play important roles in the history of religious practice within which the Chengdu armlet was made and worn. Before I examine that wider history, including its practical logics and the other objects that remain of it, it will be useful first to survey its normative discursive side, as found in the *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*. In order to keep the focus on the traditions of physical practice the spell helped to shape, rather than giving a full study of the sutra, its structures and its sources, I will survey the portions of the text that seem to have been most operative within the practical tradition—the tales of the spell’s efficacies and the guidelines for the creation of the amulets.

THE SŪTRA AND ITS SPELL

The Incantation of Wish Fulfillment first appears in the historical record in China within the first translation of its sūtra, *The Scripture of the Dhāraṇī Spirit-Spell of Great Sovereignty, Preached by the Buddha, Whereby One Immediately Attains What Is Sought*.¹¹ This text is credited to the Kashmiri monk Baosiwei (d. 721), whose original name was reconstructed by Antonino Forte as Maṇicintana.¹² His translation is dated to December 693, the year of his arrival in China, the second year of the Changshou reign period of Empress Wu Zetian, a singularly productive age in the history of dhāraṇī practice in China, particularly for those spells that require bodily engagement.¹³ The text seems, in fact, to have been translated simultaneously with another dhāraṇī manual that features related practices of wearing cords that have been empowered by incantations, the *Dafangguang pusazang jing zhong Wenshushili genben yizi tuoluoni jing*, or *The Scripture of Mañjuśrī's Root One-Syllable Dhāraṇī*.¹⁴ A later, much more elaborate and in many ways quite different scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment is credited to the powerful mid-eighth-century monk Amoghavajra, or Bukong.¹⁵ For the sake of simplicity, in this chapter I will refer to both versions as *The Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*, noting which translation I mean in each case.

Unlike the other main incantation studied in this book, the *Incantation of Glory* and its tale of the vicissitudes of the god Shanzhu, a unifying plot of redemption does not structure the Baosiwei version of the *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*. Instead, like most Buddhist incantation scriptures of its period, it consists almost entirely of a series of “just-so” stories that account for the miraculous powers of its incantation and a set of ritual formulae for their activation. In this it resembles both a number of other medium-sized dhāraṇī scriptures and the genre of large occult compendia such as the *Consecration Scripture* and the *Dhāraṇī Miscellany*—as well as a number of untitled manuscripts consisting of dhāraṇī collections discovered at Dunhuang.¹⁶

As in all texts claiming the status of Buddhist scripture, the tales and formulae of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment* are framed as teachings given by the Buddha at a particular place and time. In the case of the Baosiwei translation, that place is Mt. Gṛdhra-kūta, or “Vulture Peak,” the site where according to tradition the Buddha preached many important scriptures, most famously, perhaps, the *Lotus Sūtra*.¹⁷ The god Brahmā, who requests an incantation at the outset of the framing story, serves as the Buddha's interlocutor throughout. Brahmā initiates the conversation after he arrives and takes his place within

the Buddha's audience on Vulture Peak by announcing, "My only wish is that the World-Honored One preach a dhāraṇī spirit-incantation in order to benefit all beings. May he cause all humans and gods to universally attain security and bliss!"¹⁸ This generous wish marks the text at the outset as belonging to the mainstream of dhāraṇī-incantation manuals translated or produced in China, most of which are similarly directed toward securing the welfare of their practitioners amid the great dangers of this life and the next. In this, indeed, the incantation scriptures were themselves solidly in the mainstream of Buddhist scriptural concern, which featured from an early stage images and promises of the protection of sentient beings from the myriad dangers of the triple world.¹⁹

The most widely read Western scholarship on Buddhist incantation books in China has stressed the part spells and fears of demons played in the early medieval cultural drama of the dreaded "final period of the Buddha's Teachings" (*mofa*), or "final age" (*moshi*), the time long after the extinction of the Buddha when his teachings, along with their beneficent protective aura, were said to have faded from the world and thus no longer hindered the depredations of the evil forces that threaten it. Though one finds mention of the "final age" in dhāraṇī books through to at least the eighth century, including in the *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*, the spell book that is most centrally concerned with apocalypse is the *Consecration Scripture*. Michel Strickmann demonstrated that text's deep connection with Daoist and other native Chinese practices that were explicitly framed by eschatological fears of demonic infestations, plagues, and human decline, fears that were part of a cultural climate that contributed importantly to the rise of the Daoist religion. Indeed, the doom-laden *Consecration Scripture* and its Daoist apocalyptic cousins exhibit features of a religious discourse that in important ways characterized the early medieval period, the age when dhāraṇī-incantation texts first flourished. This discourse, in fact, is an important part of what makes the distinction between "early" and "late medieval" seem useful to historians of Chinese religion. The early medieval period, an intensely fertile age for Buddhist and Daoist ideology, stretched from the decline and final collapse of the 400-year regime of the Han Empire in the late second century—a series of events that helped unleash a wave of millenarian activity that, among other things, contributed to the rise of religious Daoism—to perhaps the final and most impressive project driven by such apocalyptic fears, the carving begun in the sixth century of the entire Buddhist canon on stone slabs at Fangshan in the northeast, near the modern city of Beijing, to be stored against the coming darkness.²⁰

Though the culture of apocalypse was a feature of the age, the dread of demons and other agents of catastrophe already had had a long history in China and in the lands to its west by the early medieval period.²¹ It needed no special millenarian framework in which to flourish. The *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment* targets, for the most part, older enemies, which the text discusses in tales of mothers, travelers, warrior-kings, and criminals. As Gergely Hidas has pointed out in his study of a later Sanskrit edition of the scripture, the text seems originally to have been composed within a wider set of amulet cults that had appeared within Buddhist communities by at the latest the middle of the first millennium CE, cults that adapted much older Indic practices, including those of *pratisara* amulet cords themselves.²² Given the Chinese contexts in which *Mahāpratisarā* amulets have been discovered, we might note in particular that the *Scripture* also features a tale of the horrors of hell: most of the amulets recovered by archeologists have been found in tombs, a fact that showcases the spell's role in mortuary practices of the late Tang, Five Dynasties, and early Song periods.²³

The Buddha responds to the god by praising his wish and by introducing the *Incantation*, summarizing the dangers it wards against and the blessings its enactments bring.²⁴

This is the “Dhāraṇī Spirit Incantation of Great Sovereignty Whereby One Immediately Attains What Is Sought.” It can give all beings surpassing security and bliss. They will not be bothered or harmed by any *yakṣas*, by any demons of plague or famine, by any *skandha* demons, or by any other sorts of demons or spirits. Neither will they be attacked or stricken by sicknesses of cold or heat. The positions they take up will ever bring victory; they will not suffer harm from the attacks of enemies in war and can destroy their opponents. Hexes, incantations, and curses cannot harm them. All wrongdoings of past lives will be eliminated. Poisons cannot harm them nor fires burn them. Blades cannot wound them and they will never drown. They cannot be hurt by thunder, lightning, or hail, or even by ill winds or terrible storms.²⁵

So far in the text, these powers are all presented simply as general attributes of the spell—no specific means for their activation have yet been described, nor any specific needs that would condition them. At this point, *dhāraṇī sūtras* typically list the standard modes of scriptural enactment: first and foremost “practicing” (literally, “receiving and holding,” *shouchi*), meaning (as

described in the introduction) to memorize, absorb, and make use of in the broadest sense. Next, like all teachings of the Buddha, spells are to be chanted and listened to. In the case of dhāraṇīs, oral, or sonic, performance and reception was usually paramount. The mystic tones of the Sanskrit were said to embody in themselves, rather than in their sense, the cosmic efficacies of the spell. Thus, the reader of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment's* scripture reasonably expects the Buddha to teach first of all the proper incantation of the spell and to praise the efficacies of this practice.

The text confounds this expectation. The first mode of practice given, and the one consistently featured in the text, is copying the spell and wearing it on the arm or at the neck as an amulet, not intoning it or hearing it intoned.²⁶ The scripture as a whole, in fact, with the exception of a few sections later on where vocal and mental incantation of the spell are advocated, is best understood as a manual for the creation and use of dhāraṇī amulets—just as earlier and contemporary dhāraṇī texts were largely manuals for the creation and use of particular sounds. The archeological evidence provided by the amulets suggests that this was indeed how the text was taken during the late Tang and afterwards, from Dunhuang in the far northwest, all the way to the region south of the Yangtze River in the southeast, where other *Mahāpratisarā* sheets have been discovered. After indicating its proper form of practice, the Buddha then begins to describe the ways the incantation confers its protections and blessings.

One who can write the spell down and wear it at his neck or on his arm will be able to complete all the meritorious acts of utmost purity and will ever be held in the protective embrace of gods and dragon kings. Furthermore, he will be recollected and thought upon by buddhas and bodhisattvas. The Secret Adamantine Lords and the Four Great Heavenly Kings, even the god Śakra and the Great God of the Brahmā Heavens, the god Viṣṇu, the god Maheśvara, the legions of *kumāra* Indra, hordes of *vināyaka*, the Great Black God (*Mahākāla*), Nandi, and *Jishuo tian*—day and night they will ever closely follow and keep in their protective embrace the bearer of this spell.²⁷

The Buddha, soon after listing these protector gods, generalizes the bodily reception of the spell. Not only the neck and arm offer efficacious positions at which to secure an amulet. He states simply that “if this spirit-incantation is kept on the body or in hand,” its magic is activated, and general protection and benisons flow from it. But elsewhere, in this text and in others, much is

made of the different circumstances that call for holding the spell, and the different ways the dhāraṇī may be worn as an amulet. Each endows and figures its own special virtue. These are central elements of dhāraṇī-amulet practice—in fact, one might argue that they are what basically constitute it. Since most of these techniques are neither attested in the archeological record nor much discussed in scholarship, a sample of prescribed forms for the wearing of the incantation will be useful.

The first specific circumstances described by the Buddha are those faced by women who, according to both Indian and Chinese societal dictates, are required to give birth to sons, and whose positions in the families they have married into are perhaps thus never fully secure. Along with freedom from physical pain and illness during childbirth, the spell offers women security and blessings within the family and offers their children the same within the womb.

If a woman receives and holds this spirit spell, she will have great positional power²⁸ and will ever give birth to males. If she receives and holds it while pregnant then what is within her womb will be secure in its fastness. While giving birth she will be secure and joyful and without any sickness. The sins she committed in past lives will be eliminated and she will surely be without karmic obstructions. Because of the power of the spell's blessings, her household will prosper and the teachings and commands she speaks will all be trustfully received and will always be treated as honored matters.²⁹

This passage does not mention any particular style for wearing the spell, but later in the text the neck or throat is prescribed for women wishing to conceive. A king named Merciful Hand, who is singularly blessed in all things save in his queen's inability to conceive, is visited one night by a god.

Later, one night, the king saw the god of the pure abode (*jingju tianzi*)³⁰ who came over to him and said, "Great king, you should know that there is a great spirit-incantation named *Seeking and Immediately Attaining*. If the king can, according to the rite, copy it out and give it to your queen to tie about her throat, she will immediately attain a son." When the king awoke, dawn had already arrived. He then straightaway copied out the great spirit-incantation according to the rite and gave it to his queen to wear. There was a mystical response and she became pregnant. When the sun and moon were full, she gave birth to a son who was completely

endowed with all the visible marks [of a great man] and such a superlatively austere demeanor that all who saw him were joyful. Great Brahmā, [the Buddha continues,] you should know that the might of this spirit-incantation is such that those who seek it will always attain satisfaction.³¹

For children already born—boys or girls—the Buddha next describes the particular forms of safety, health, ease, and happiness during childhood conferred by wearing the incantation. Several of the usual dangers said to be warded off by the dhāraṇī—disease, the effects of previous karma, spiritual and physical attack—are present here, but in forms that speak particularly to parents' fears for their children, including bad dreams and the predations of evil people.

If boys or girls hold this spell, they will be secure and blissful, without any illness, and will have bright and fulsome appearances. They will be complete in their good fortunes and their blessings will increase. All of their enchantments [zhoufa] will be successful. If they wear this charm, even though they do not enter altars they will, through this practice, attain the entering of all altars, and will engage in the same practices as those who have entered altars.³² They will not have evil dreams and their heavy transgressions of previous lives will be eliminated. If those who have given rise to evil thoughts come towards them they will not be able to harm the holders of this incantation. All the joys and desirables sought by the holder of this incantation will be attained.³³

Parents were not the only target audiences. After chanting the syllables of the incantation so that those surrounding him could learn them, the Buddha tells other tales of their usefulness.³⁴ Though the text clearly emphasizes writing and wearing the spell as an amulet, it also gives a few examples of more traditional ways to enact it as a spoken or memorized incantation. These accounts are mainly sandwiched into the middle of the narrative, immediately following the Buddha's own oral presentation of the dhāraṇī, a fact that further suggests the secondary status of traditional incantation practices within it. After intoning the spell, the Buddha says, "If good men or good women even briefly hear this dhāraṇī, all their sinful blockages without exception will be completely eliminated. If they chant and hold it, then you should know that these people are the Diamond Body [that is, the uncreated indestructible true nature of reality]. Fires cannot burn them." The motif of the Diamond body, of the transformation of mortal impure flesh into the rarefied and luminous substance of

ultimate reality, recurs in the text and is, as I will explore in more detail in the next chapter, perhaps the central trope of dhāraṇī practice, even of the incantations themselves. Enacting the spell works an inconceivable alchemy:

You should know that this person is the body of the Thus-Come One. You should know that he is the Diamond Body. You should know that he is the body of the Storehouse of the Thus-Come One. You should know that he is the eye of the Thus-Come One. You should know that he has donned the armor of the Thus-Come One. You should know that he is the brilliant and luminous body. You should know that he is the indestructible body.³⁵

At times the tradition asserts that this transformation is effected through the figurative “embrace” of the Buddha, at other times simply through physical or mental contact with the incantation. In this text, this contact comes in the usual two main forms of bodily enchantment: direct enchanting and adornment with an enchanted amulet. The direct application of incanted tones onto the body is less emphasized in the *Scripture*, but does occur, as in the tale of a Buddhist layman who came to the aid of a sorcerer poisoned by the bite of a *taṣṣaka* (*dechajia*), a dragonlike beast the *Lotus Sūtra* identifies as a lord of his kind,³⁶ which the sorcerer had summoned but been unable to master. The layman, enchanting the sorcerer’s body with the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*—“but once,” the text emphasizes—is able to cure him completely of the poison (and, naturally, to convert him to the practice of the dhāraṇī).³⁷

The *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment* gives several examples of such spell amulets, all in the form of tales of the spell’s power, but a look at three—of a criminal, a warrior-king, and a deceased monk—will give a clear sense of the pattern.

Great Brahmā, in the city of Uddyana (*wuchanna*) there was a king named Brahmadāna (*fanshi*). A man of the city had committed a crime against the king and been condemned to death. The king decreed that the execution be carried out and the man was taken into the mountains and the executioner’s blade made ready. The man wore upon his right arm this incantation, and because of its spiritual might the blade burst into flame, burned, and scattered as ash. The official of the law who witnessed this thought it strange and unprecedented. He straightaway went back to the king and completely reported what had happened. The

king told the officer of the law that in the mountains there was a *yakṣa* demon cave, within which dwelled innumerable *yakṣa* demons. The officer was to send the guilty man into the cave. Thereupon the officer of the law, upholding his commands, went to send the man into the cave. When the guilty man entered the cave the *yakṣas* came to eat him. However, because of the awesome might of the incantation the *yakṣas* and other beasts all saw the man's body shining with brilliant light. They then escorted the guilty man out of the cave and honored and worshipped him. Once again, the officer of the law reported these matters to the king. The king then ordered that the guilty man be cast into a great river. Upholding the order, the officer of the law went and cast the guilty man into the river. When he had been cast in, however, he did not sink and drown but stepped upon the water as if it were land. The officer of the law returned and made this matter known to the great king. The king was terribly shocked at the strangeness of it all. He called for the guilty man and asked about his methods. "How have you escaped?" The guilty man answered the king, "Your vassal has not escaped. On my body I merely wear the *Dhāraṇī Spirit-Incantation of Great Sovereignty Whereby One Immediately Attains What Is Sought*." The king thought this wondrous beyond all measure.³⁸

The spell is, however, as useful in the expression of royal power as it is in its vexation. Curiously, though the following describes a different man, the king in it is also named "Brahmadāna":

Great Brahmā, the city of Varanasi had a king named Brahmadāna. Once, a neighboring king of great majesty and power roused the four troops of his army [that is, elephants, chariots, cavalry, and infantry] and came to attack him. When the fourfold army arrived at Varanasi city, King Brahmadāna knew what to do. He commanded the people within the city: "Do not be afraid. I have a spirit-incantation named the *Dhāraṇī of Immediately Attaining That Which One Seeks*. The might of this spirit incantation can crush even a fourfold army." At this time, Brahmadāna bathed himself clean and donned new clean robes. He wrote out the spell and held it on his body. Then he went out alone onto the battlefield. The fourfold army submitted to him and came over to his side. Great Brahmā, you should know that such is the might of this spirit-incantation.³⁹

As the king's ritual preparations suggest, the *Scripture* also makes clear that purely physical modes of enacting the spell—that is, simply wearing it—were at times combined with devotional or meditative practices. The Buddha asserts in the text that “the Seal of the Thus-Come One”—that is, given the context, the written *Incantation* worn as an amulet—“ever responds to recollection and mental recitation.”⁴⁰ Such statements complicate any too-simple picture of the spell's practice as consisting solely of physical contact or adornment that might arise from a study of the material record alone, since the excavated objects are mute about the full nature of the ways people engaged them in practice. There are, however, hints in that record that the spell amulets were considered more than simply protective physical adornments, the wearing of which alone was thought to be enough. The colophon printed on Stein Painting 249, discussed previously, interestingly diverges from the text of the sutra, which it otherwise simply quotes, by adding the statement “if one . . . makes offerings to it [that is, the written incantation], one will be fit for protection and purification.” This addition reminds us that *dhāraṇīs* were at times understood to function as buddhas and bodhisattvas—to respond to contemplation and devotion, for example—and, more than that, in the logic of certain forms of worship to *be* buddhas, or at least synecdochic fragments of their bodies (relics). Aside from, once again, complicating any too-simple distinction between the three ways of imagining written spells explored in the previous chapter, this fact reminds us that cognitive and emotional engagement is never far away in Buddhist practice, even in its most apparently mechanical forms.⁴¹

Yet most descriptions of wearing Buddhist spells as phylacteries from this period do not emphasize the cognitive or devotional component. The third of the sutra's tales I offer here as emblematic starts us back toward the excavated amulets, providing what would seem to have been scriptural warrant for using them to adorn corpses to protect and bless the dead.

Great Brahmā, you should know that in ancient days there was a bhikṣu of little faith, a monk deficient in his practice of the precepts who committed theft. He went into and made use of both the personal belongings of monks and the common property and provisions of the saṃgha. Later, this bhikṣu became gravely ill and experienced terrible vexations. A Brahmin upāsaka,⁴² great compassion arising within him, wrote out this spirit incantation and tied it to the monk's neck. As soon as he tied it, the monk's illnesses and sufferings, without exception, were

all extinguished. Later, when his life span came to an end, the monk tumbled into Avīci Hell. The corpse of the bhikṣu entombed in its stupa, however, still bore the spell upon it. The stupa was located to the south of today's Fulfillment City.⁴³ Because the bhikṣu entered into hell he experienced all its agonies for a time, [yet] they ceased and he attained [instead] security and bliss. The flames of hell went out completely.

A soldier of hell, witnessing these events, was greatly astonished. He reported it all to King Yama, who then told the soldier: "This is [due to] the awesome virtue of a remainder from a previous life. You must go to the south of Fulfillment City and see what manner of object it is." Receiving this command, the soldier left. Arriving at the stupa just at the beginning of evening, he saw light coming from it like a great fire. Within the stupa he saw the monk's corpse adorned with this very *Dhāraṇī Spirit-Incantation of Great Sovereignty Whereby One Immediately Attains What Is Sought*. Furthermore, there were gods surrounding and protecting it. The soldier of hell, then, perceiving that the power of this incantation was inconceivable, named the stupa "Immediately Attaining What is Sought." The soldier of hell thereupon returned and reported all that he had seen to King Yama. The bhikṣu, having absorbed the power of the incantation such that all his sins were eradicated, attained birth in the Heaven of Thirty-Three. Because of this, this god [the former bhikṣu] was named Immediately Attaining What is Sought.

Great Brahmā, you should know that one who writes out this incantation according to the proper rite and wears it on his body will ever be without suffering, will be benefited in all things, and will have all his fears swept away.⁴⁴

This last story achieved popularity well beyond that of the others contained in the sutra. The eleventh-century collection of Buddhist miracle tales, *Sanbao ganying yaolüe lu*, or *Abridged Essentials of the Spiritual Resonance of the Three Jewels*, compiled by the monk Feizhuo (d. 1063), contains (as its title suggests) a shortened version of the tale, entitled "The Spiritual Resonance of Writing the *Dhāraṇī* of Wish Fulfillment and Fastening It To the Neck To Eliminate Sins."⁴⁵ The version is a slightly altered retelling of the first section of the *Scripture's* tale (its first paragraph, in my translation above), which recounts the basic feat of the spell—the releasing from torment of the sinners imprisoned in the worst of all Buddhist hells, and the complete dousing of its terrible flames.

With its transformation of the hell-bound deceased into a god through the power of a dhāraṇī, this narrative echoes a popular tale of the *Incantation of Glory* I will discuss in the next chapter, where afterlife concerns will feature prominently. The present tale, along with the others I have translated here, offers, in several ways, a convenient capsule of the incantatory imagery and promise featured in the *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*. It contains many of the basics not only of the mortuary imagination of dhāraṇīs, but of dhāraṇīs in all practical contexts common in this period: the protection of divinities invoked by the spell; the luminous, fiery substance of the spell itself, which quells all other fires, whether the intense flames of the lowest and worst hell or the normal worldly fires of earth; as well as the promise that all agents of evil destinies, structural and personal, are impotent against it. The very workings of karma itself, inexorable in the mainstream doctrines of monks and scriptures, dissolve when the transcendent power of the spell is brought into play.

These are central features of the imagination and practice of dhāraṇīs. In the next chapter I will confront questions of what they reveal about the ways Buddhist incantations were imagined and understood, and what such imaginings as we find in these tales of their inconceivably potent, pure, and luminous substances suggest about how medieval Chinese Buddhists understood their own mortal and corruptible human bodies, as well as what the tales suggest about the mortal anxieties and desires that were in many ways the engine of the tradition itself. In this chapter my interest focuses more narrowly on small details of physical practice and on broad practical history. Why were spells to be tied to one's neck or arm, or fastened in one's hair or to the corner of one's robe? How were such seemingly common and innocuous practices understood in China in the latter centuries of the first millennium CE, where there existed an extremely rich palette of similar but culturally and religiously distinct options?

Keeping in mind, then, the Buddha's tale of the transfigured monk and his necklace of potent syllables, as well as the other promises and techniques of redemption and ease promised in the scriptural tales of the spell, we can now turn back to our anonymous skeleton, mute in its tomb by the Jin River, those same syllables on its arm.

WEARING DHĀRAṆĪ AMULETS

To date, at least twenty-three *Mahāpratisarā* amulets have been found in China, consisting, usually—as in the Chengdu example sketched before—of a sheet containing intricate combinations of text and image and a case in which the

sheet was carried on the body.⁴⁶ The sheets come in three basic forms: manuscripts (of which nine have been discovered), xylographs (eleven), and sheets that were partly printed and partly hand drawn (three). The dates of many of the amulet sheets remain highly tentative, but their chronology appears in general to follow along the lines of the development of xylography in China in the late centuries of the first millennium CE, proceeding from pure manuscripts, to sheets partially printed but with crucial sections drawn or written in by hand, and finally to fully printed examples, whose structures are in essential ways quite different from those of the earlier manuscripts. Most of the sheets are of paper, though three examples, including two that seem very early, were done on silk. The sheets range in size from 21.5 × 21.5 cm (Madame Wei's amulet) to 44.5 × 44.3 (the monk Xingsi's), with later examples often (but not always) larger than those of earlier periods. The first two formats, manuscripts and half-manuscripts, tend to share many features, which in general follow the dictates of the *Scripture*—imagery of empowerment and bearer's names included within the texts of the spells, for example—enough so that I will take them in this chapter to constitute the “early style” of amulet production. Amulets in the “late style,” in contrast, depart in key respects from the earlier-style amulets, and from the scripture that in part inspired them, containing features that appear to have been drawn both from newer developments in Buddhist ritual practice and from those in the craft of block printing.

The earliest among all extant amulet sheets appears to be the manuscript once carried by a certain Madame Wei (Wei Daniang), now held in the collection of the Yale University Art Gallery, dating to the early mid-eighth century, and probably (according to the judgment of Ma Shichang) to the reign of the Tang emperor Xuanzong (685–762; r. 712–756)⁴⁷ (figure 2.3). The latest example with a clear connection to amulet practice is the Dunhuang example mentioned at the start of this chapter. It was found without a case and is clearly dated to 980, early in the Song Dynasty, in an age known in Dunhuang more specifically as that of the “Army of Returned Righteousness” (*Guiyijun*, 848–1036), which was marked by a return to the region of Han Chinese rule after many years of Tibetan control. Two others are still later—dating to 1001 and 1005—but were discovered in reliquary (or quasi-reliquary) contexts, though as I will discuss later they remain important for this study.

I will describe and analyze the sheets, and the great amount of Buddhist history and culture they reveal, later in this chapter. I focus my attention here

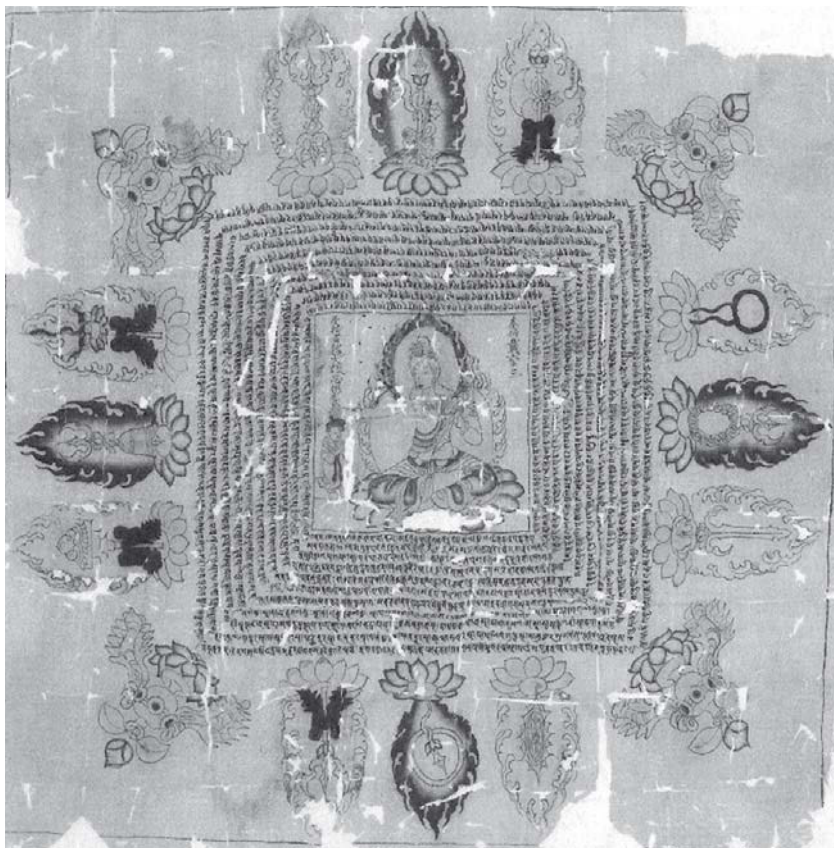


FIGURE 2.3

Madame Wei Mahāpratisarā amulet. Eighth century? Yale University Art Gallery (“Tantric Buddhist Charm,” 1955:7.1a). Hobart and Edward Small Moore Memorial Collection, bequest of Mrs. William H. Moore. Ink and colors on silk. 21.5 cm × 21.5 cm.

first on their much simpler (and much less studied) carrying cases, analysis of which reveals equally rich and storied histories of Asian religious practice and imagination. The cases come in three basic kinds: simple containers—either round, as in the case of Madame Wei’s amulet (figure 2.4), tube-shaped, or in rectangular boxes—that seem to have been carried in pockets or in pouches; pendants worn around the neck (and some of the tube-shaped cases may have been worn on cords around the neck);⁴⁸ or armlets fastened to the upper arm. These latter two forms are, given the meaning of *pratisara* as bracelet or necklace, clearly of special resonance in the spell’s tradition across Asia. Four



FIGURE 2.4

Madame Wei Mahapratīsarā amulet case. Bronze. Yale University Art Gallery (“Tantric Buddhist Charm,” 1955.7.1b). Hobart and Edward Small Moore Memorial Collection, bequest of Mrs. William H. Moore (1955.7.1).

examples of armlets have been discovered in Chinese tombs, the most of any one style of amulet case; a few others seem to have been worn as pendants. The armlets range from simple rings, as in the Chengdu amulet (figure 2.5) and its twin (see below), which was also printed in Chengdu but discovered outside of Xi’an; and slightly more involved pieces, including an amulet once belonging to a man named “Iron-head Jiao” (Jiao Tietou), which include a tube-shaped or square box fastened to the arm ring—perhaps a combination of the rings and boxes noted above (figure 2.6).⁴⁹

These armlets, especially, dramatically widen the context for our understanding of Tang dhāraṇī practice out into a broad trans-Asian sphere and help us to connect back in a concrete way to the region in which the sūtra itself was originally produced. In doing so, they reveal striking continuities between Tang China and the Buddhist lands to its west. Though there is little historical information about the immediate practical and conceptual contexts of any one Chinese amulet, given the long history of *pratisara*-style cord and amulet practice, there is a wealth of material with which to consider the broader contexts of their practical and conceptual history. The rings

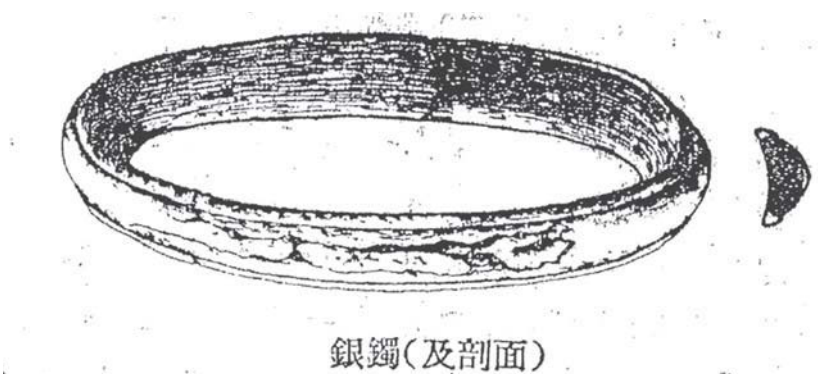


FIGURE 2.5

Drawing of silver armlet from Tang-era tomb, Sichuan. After Feng, "Ji Tang yinben tuoluoni," 70.

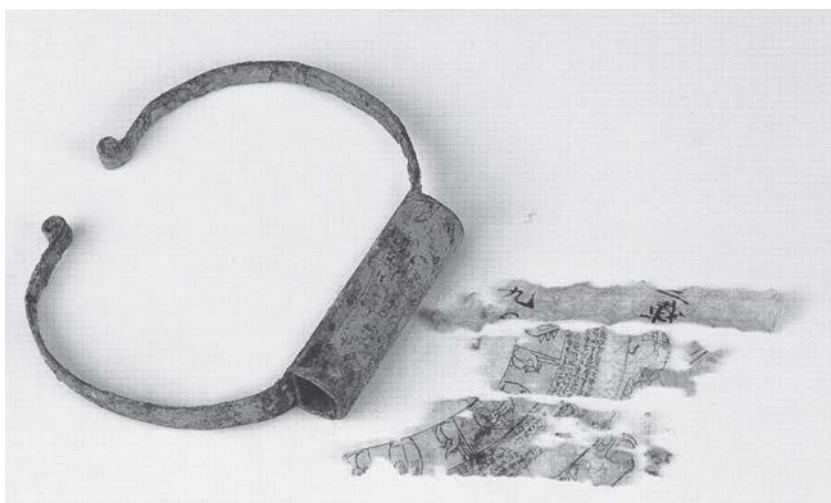


FIGURE 2.6

Armlet. Tang Dynasty. Gold-enamelled bronze (1 cm w.) with copper box riveted to it (4.5 × 2.4 cm). After Li and Guan, "Xi'an xijiao chutu."

(along with the parallel group of dhāraṇī pendants) are vivid evidence of Chinese connections with this long and geographically far-reaching history of Indic Buddhist practice that included both ancient rites of bodily enchantment as well as, perhaps, mimetic responses to the visual splendor of bodhisattvas and their jeweled adornments. It is to accounts of those practices that I now turn.

INCANTATION CORDS AND ARMLETS

Though Chinese had by the eighth century CE worn textual amulets for (at least) hundreds of years, the styles for doing so (not to mention the specific texts) evidenced in these tombs seem to have been wholly new to them.⁵⁰ The question, then, of why Iron-head Jiao and his anonymous cousin in dhāraṇī practice buried by the Jin river in Chengdu wore their incantations in metallic armlets takes us deep into the details of the normative accounts of bodily incantation practice that survive in dhāraṇī scriptures. Examined in that context, it becomes clear that Jiao's incantation-bearing armlet was part of a set of practices that in Buddhism was already at least hundreds of years old by his day, a set whose contents ranged from the enchanting and wearing of knotted cords, sometimes strung with pearls, seeds, or beads, to armlets filled with similar enchanted objects or the texts of spells—and note that from one perspective, an enspelled seed and a written spell are the same in the sense that both serve as delivery methods for the potencies of incantations. In parallel with dhāraṇīs themselves, these ritual objects were in their earliest textual descriptions the foci (usually along with one or two others) of the rites that featured them. That is, the rites described center on the construction of objects such as enchanted armlets. In the later longer and more elaborate ritual texts of the Esoteric Buddhist tradition, such as the eighth-century Chinese version of the *Susiddhikara*, these objects, like the incantations used to enchant them, recede into the background, becoming but one among a number of objects ancillary to the main focus of the rite. But within the earlier simpler practical tradition and its later exemplars—such as those instantiated within the Chinese tombs under discussion here—they remained the principal focus.⁵¹

The practice of tying an amulet to the body with a cord called a *prati-sara*, or of treating the cord itself as an amulet, was already very old in Indic practice—described already in the *Atharva Veda*—by the time it appears in Buddhist sources.⁵² Such cords were not only used to spiritually secure the

person in Indic practices, but as Anna A. Ślāczka has recently described, they were also used to secure and empower the bricks used in the construction of shrines in ancient India.⁵³ The ritual and material logics governing the securing of bodily persons and locales thus appear to have been as closely related in Indian practices as they were in China, where, as we saw in chapter 1, practical continuities connected *zhai fa*, the “methods of [the protection of] the abode,” and *hushen*, the “[methods of the] protection of the bodily person.”

In the case of protective threads, Indic and Sinitic practices appear to have been especially close. Quite similar techniques were practiced in both cultural regions. Though I have found no direct links between native Chinese practices of protective threads and those used by bearers of amulets of the *Wish-Fulfilling Spell*, it is possible that already by the first two centuries of the Common Era five-colored cords were employed to protect gates in China, as reported in the fifth-century *Hou Han shu*. Further, though mention of this practice postdates the earliest Buddhist examples by a century or so, by the mid-sixth century such techniques had been extended to the bodily person. Zong Lin, in his *Jingchu suishi ji*, which dates to around the 550s, reports: “One fastens threads of five colors to the arm. This is called a ‘weapon averter.’ It wards off illness and plague.”⁵⁴

The oldest account of wearing an enchanted arm ring or cord that I have found in a Buddhist work also characterizes its cord as a “weapon averter.” It is in the late fourth- or early fifth-century text called in Chinese the *Wuming luocha ji*, the *Collection of the Ignorant Rākṣasa*. In one of the central tales of this work, a king ventures out of his palace alone to do battle with demons who have laid waste his capital city. The monarch girds himself for the fight in a way reminiscent of the preparations of King Brahmadāna described in the *Scripture of the Wish-Fulfilling Spell*. Along with rubbing his body with powerful medicines, donning “the armor of the Wish-Fulfilling Jewel” (*ruyibao kai*), and taking up a sharp blade, he “ties an incantation cord (*zhousuo*) to his body.”⁵⁵ This small detail—which reflects the practice of wearing “sacred threads” seen in Indic cultures even today, and which are found in *dhāraṇī* manuals as “spirit threads” (*shenxian*)—reappears in later ritual manuals, where it is enlarged and described in more detail.

In Buddhist ritual texts, the enchanting and wearing of an incantation cord is usually one among a few different means for the application of the potency of spells to the body, including direct enchanting and the spreading

of spell-empowered substances, such as ash, onto the body. Jñānagupta's (523–600) late-sixth-century *Rulai fangbian shanqiao zhoujing*, *The Incantation Scripture of the Thus-Come One's Skill in Means* offers two versions of a typical rite whose objective, protection from plague, demons, and enemies, shows once again the somewhat narrow purview of bodily incantation rites and their conservatism over time.

Should any good sons or daughters wish to eliminate illness, they should take a five-colored twine and knot it into an incantation cord. If there is a plague, they should take *sumanā* flower oil, and enchant it one hundred and eight times, then apply it to the body. A cure will immediately be effected. To protect your own body and make it secure and remote [from illness?], enchant water one hundred and eight times and scatter it to the four quarters in order to secure the ritual space. Take a five-colored twine, knot it into an incantation cord and wear it where you go.⁵⁶

Should any good sons or good daughters be in the grips of evil demons, they should take a twine and make it into an incantation cord, enchant it one hundred and eight times and wear it whether they walk or sit. This will rid them of all such evil demons. They should as well take *sumanā* flowers, good and pure cow butter, white mustard seeds, or other such things, and, establishing a [ritual] place, chant the spell each time one part of these is cast into the fire, continuing in this way one hundred and eight times. At the one hundred and eighth time the cure will be effected. Should an evil person desire to do you harm, take a blade of fine iron and enchant it one hundred and eight times. Cut the road the man walks; he will then not be able to do harm. Alternatively: enchant water and scatter it to the four quarters, forming in this way the four quarters of a ritual space. Occupy its center. No evil will be able to attach itself to you. Should one wish to protect oneself and be safe from harm, take a five-colored twine and make it into a rope. Enchant it one hundred and eight times and wear it whether you walk or sit.⁵⁷

Xuanzang's mid-seventh-century translation of the *Amoghapāśa-dhāraṇī-sūtra*, the *Bukong juansuo shenzhou xinjing*, or *The Heart Sūtra of the Spirit-Incantation of the Unfailing Lariat*, a central text of the cult of one of the so-called "esoteric forms" of Avalokiteśvara, places the creation and wearing of incantation cords

within, once again, a larger field of practices for securing both bodies and spaces from harmful influences.

For misfortunes of cold or heat and for feverish illness, one should enchant a knotted twine twenty-one times and tie it either to the neck or to the arm—all illness will immediately dissipate. Alternatively, enchant butter, oil, or water twenty-one times and give it to the patient to ingest—he will immediately be cleared of illness and cured. Those who wish to be freed from another's incantations and curses should take a substance such as mud, dough, honey, or wax and use it to form his image [that is, that of the offending sorcerer]. Orally chant this spell while holding in your hand a hard blade. With feelings of great compassion and mercy for the sorcerer, cut the image. Furthermore, with an enchanted twine tie up the wearied body [of the image?]. This will cause all fear immediately to be cleared away and cured. For all pains of the abdomen, one should enchant salty water and give it to the patient to be ingested—the pains will thereby be dissipated and cured. For all bites or stings of venomous creatures such as snakes or scorpions, enchant water and have the patient drink it, then enchant mud and spread it on him—he will immediately be cleared and cured. For all ailments and pains of the eyes, one should enchant a white twine and tie it to the ears—one will immediately be cleared and cured. For all tooth ailments or pains, one should enchant acacia wood twenty-one times and then chew on it—one will immediately be cleared and cured. For all terrifying places, one should seal a ritual space (*jiejie*) there and dwell within it. Here is the method for sealing the space: enchant a five-colored twine twenty-one times and wrap mountain stakes (*shanjue*) in it, then nail the four corners of the space with the stakes—you will then immediately achieve fearlessness.⁵⁸ All who desire self-protection should enchant twine and wear it on their bodies. Alternatively, they can enchant water and ash and sprinkle it over their bodies. All those whose bodies have been possessed by demons, spirits, or faeries should enchant five-colored twine and constantly wear it—they will immediately be released from the hold of these beings.⁵⁹

Most of these techniques, with the notable exception here of the ritual manipulation of a simulacrum, are from one perspective, reductive but illuminating, a single technique: the application of a *dhāraṇī* to afflicted parts

of the body through a physical medium such as twine, oil, water, wood, ash, or mud. Their bodily focus also connects them within a larger set: the securing of some locality, whether it be the physical person, the home, the city, or the nation against harm from such menaces as storms, plagues, enemies, or demonic attack. The basics of the rites in this larger set, again, are in general the same as those we see in this passage: an incantation, through the medium of a physical object or substance, is physically placed in a way that it confers protection (from a conventional and rather small set of dangers) over the chosen area.⁶⁰ This, in broad strokes, is the nature of the family in which we find the practices of the *dhāraṇīs* of *Wish Fulfillment* and *Glory*.

Within that deceptively simple family, however, and sticking for now only with bodily techniques, revealing distinctions in the precise *logics* of its members' enactments can be discerned. As I began to explore in the previous chapter, two principal distinctions in that logic, which in fact structure the central portion of this book, are at play in this passage: that between the *direct* application of an incantation to the body—through such means as the chewing of enchanted wood or the smearing of enchanted mud onto the flesh—and the *wearing* of an incantation-empowered object. In both modes the physical presence of the incantation is key. Yet the styles of interaction with it differ in ways that, when they are spun out, outline rather different modes of human behavior, and contrasting metaphors and ritual poetics: anointment and adornment. Granted, in the three passages quoted above this analytical distinction is faint, and given that no distinctions at all are made in the texts themselves it may perhaps be questionable in those specific contexts. Yet, when one situates these small objects (strings, bits of wood, handfuls of mud and ash) and practices (wearing, biting, smearing) within broader trends in the history of Buddhist practice, as I do in this chapter and in the next, small distinctions such as this one grow large. When the family of practices of which they were part is traced out in larger sets of ritual behavior, wider and separate realms of practice and imagination are revealed. Iron-head Jiao's armlet and its cousins are best understood as part of a family of adornment practices, rather than one consisting of images of simple bodily contact or unction such as those featured centrally in the rites of the *Incantation of Glory*. I thus leave aside exploration of the latter set of practices until the next chapter and turn now to a more focused discussion of the wearing of enchanted objects and inscribed enchantments.

In later texts of the more ritually integrated Buddhist Tantras, somewhat more elaborate armlets (*bichuan*)—though not yet it seems the metallic variety found in Tang tombs or (as we will see) figured in statuary—take the place of

the simple knotted incantation cords in some ritual milieus. These rings, consisting primarily of pearls or seeds, often “seeds of the Tree of Awakening” (or their ritual stand-ins),⁶¹ strung together and enchanted, become (along with “spirit threads” and other objects) standard parts of the protective armor the spell caster—the *mantrin* or *vidyādhara*—dons as he prepares himself for his rites. Such “personal protective objects” (*hushen zhi wu*), as they are called in the eighth-century Chinese translation of the *Susiddhikara-sūtra*,⁶² an early Esoteric text of pivotal importance in the history of the ritual use of apotropaic armlets, hark back to the king in the *Ignorant Rākṣasa* tale and his incantation cord, as well as to the neck circlet of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment* worn by King Brāhmadāna. The ritualist girds himself for entry into the mystic arena in the same way, and for the same reasons, as does the warrior king on the verge of the battlefield. Here again we can note the “dual track” development of ritual methods: the pre-Esoteric use of protective rings, taken in one direction via *dhāraṇī* practice into the elaborate preparations of Esoteric rites, yet maintained in non-Esoteric practices (those of the Chinese tombs, for example, along with those of our kings and wanderers) as wards against the perils of this life and the next.

It is on images of deities, however—often painted as the devotional foci of *dhāraṇī* and Esoteric rites—and in the written prescriptions for their creations, that we most often find the sort of metallic armlets evidenced in the Chinese tombs. Such images and accounts provide the final ingredient in the practical history connecting the tomb armlets to their cousins in earlier Indian Buddhist ritual practice. The creation of devotional images, whether in geometric *maṇḍalas* centered in the ritual arena, or on walls to its side, is in most *dhāraṇī* and Esoteric rites a key element in the setup of the ritual space. The texts are very specific about the images to be depicted; in fact they often consist in fairly large part mainly of iconographic descriptions detailing not only the visual character and number of arms, heads, and eyes possessed by each divinity but importantly as well the specific shape, color, and placement of its adornments. Among these divine accoutrements armlets figure prominently. A description of how to render the image of Hayagrīva Avalokiteśvara from the *Dhāraṇī Collection Scripture* provides a representative example, and one that makes clear the fact that armlets are among the most standard features of bodhisattva images—to the extent that they often do not require special iconographic descriptions of their own. After relating the expressions, colors, and dispositions of the image’s four heads, and the positions of its arms and legs, the text notes: “aside from these, its armlet and divine apparel should

all be in accord with bodhisattva images painted elsewhere.”⁶³ In other texts more specific renderings are required. Amoghavajra’s version of the *Scripture of the One Syllable Wheel-Turning Ruler Spoken at the Seat of Enlightenment* specifies that in painting one particular armlet, it should be made to appear of “pure gold.” “Make it the color of Jambūnada gold,” the text says, indicating the surpassing golden hue of the sands of the river that passes between the jambu trees of Buddhist legend.⁶⁴

The adornments of deities, furthermore, their specific characters and positions, mark each divinity as itself. Visually, but also in terms of Buddhist ritual imaginations, they are the very substance and nature of the deity, to the extent that many divinities—most notably “Vajra-Wielder” (Vajradhara or Vajrapāṇi) and “Unfailing Lariat” (Amoghapāśa)—are defined and identified nearly entirely through what they hold in their hands. This idea of the specialized characters of individualized gods (perhaps not unlike pantheons of other traditions that feature gods of “the forge,” etc.) is elaborated in Buddhist tradition in part through the concept of *samaya* (sanmeiye), the class name for these divine emblems. The polyvalence of this term, whose meanings range from “vow” to “communion” and “to rouse,” as with so many important Buddhist terms—including “dhāraṇī” itself—is one key to understanding its resonance in the tradition. The adornments and implements of the bodhisattvas and other deities figure their particular potencies and concerns, or vows (in ritual manuals and spaces, in paintings and sculptures, in scriptural narratives) and offer important sites of communion, or interface, between human and divinity, and vivid objects of longing and devotional mimesis.⁶⁵ As Martin J. Powers has recently noted in a similar vein of materials from classical China, “every ornament is a demonstration of a set of human qualities. Whoever possesses the ornament possesses these qualities.”⁶⁶ Emerging already in Dharmarakṣa’s (d. 316) late-third-century translation of the *Jātaka Sūtra* we find prayers in Buddhism for the transcendence of human life that focus on the ornaments of bodhisattvas as metonyms for the divine state: “I would attain,” a figure in the text declares, “the hundred necklaces and adornments [of the bodhisattvas], the armlets of jasper . . .”⁶⁷

In the context of the present study, the mimetic style of longing and devotion in Chinese religious history is perhaps best suggested by a juxtaposition of the image figured by the skeleton in the Jin River tomb (figure 2.1) with those of bodhisattva statues that survive from the first millennium CE. Armlets as standard features of bodhisattvas and other Buddhist divinities are not only found described in the ritual manuals of dhāraṇī and Tantric practice.

In line with the scriptural iconographic injunctions sampled above, bodhisattvas are very often depicted in Gandhāran sculpture with elaborate rings on their right arms—in precisely the position the nameless Chengdu Buddhist wore his simpler dhāraṇī-bearing armlet. I do not know of any text that tells Buddhists to mimic the adornments of bodhisattvas on their own persons, but such modeling was, along with the tradition of enchanted cords outlined before, perhaps part of the reason for the placement of the Chengdu armlet.⁶⁸

But there is another and simpler reason why both corpses and statues bore armlets at the same location: the bodhisattva arm rings and the enchanted armlets described in the ritual manuals and dhāraṇī scriptures were part of the same ancient heritage of *pratisara* amulets, a heritage that found one of its most explicit and canonical forms in the *Mahāpratisarā Sūtra*. These small objects and their practices connect in an identifiable subtradition of practice and legend the Gandhāran bodhisattvas and their beautiful adornments, the kings of legend bearing incantation cords onto the field of battle, the mantrins of the scriptures preparing for their rites, and our Chinese laypeople in their tombs. The richness and complexity of the practical tradition these figures represent comes into yet clearer focus when the dhāraṇī armlets are considered more closely in relation with the tradition's other objects. Though Buddhists such as Iron-head Jiao carried forward, perhaps consciously, what was by their time a centuries-old practice of wearing enchanted arm rings, or *pratisara*, the new forms of their amulets appear to have been in a crucial way unprecedented. The physical inclusion of an inscribed spell (whether handwritten or printed) though carrying forward the old logic of empowerment by incantation, was an important technical innovation from the simpler sonic enchantment of an arm cord. As far as I have found, there are no explicit accounts of what lay behind this change in material religious practice, but one might speculate that, as a purely technical innovation, it may have been an adaptation at least in part inspired by the textual reliquary practices surveyed in the previous chapter—the insertion of a brief text within a stupa—and other styles of amulets, evidenced also on the Gandhāran statues and explored later, which by the eighth century had widespread and ancient currency across Asia. Simply based on the historical chronology and the family resemblances among this group of objects, it would seem that the incantation cords, the metallic armlet adornments of Buddhist deities, and the tradition of placing potent phrases within cases for various purposes came together, as it were, in the form of the dhāraṇī armlets. These objects were thus (at least) triply resonant in practical tradition and religious imagination.

Though they describe not arm rings but cords to be tied to the neck—also, as I have noted, an important site of dhāraṇī interventions on the body and another basic form of *pratisara*—there are scriptural tales that give somewhat more specific instructions for the construction of dhāraṇī amulets combining the forms of incantation cords and the wearing of written spells told of in the *Mahāpratisarā* scripture. Descriptions such as these may help in the historical connect-the-dots I engage in here in an attempt to give a useful account of the armlets and their practices. The *Dhāraṇī Collection Scripture*, an anthology dating in China to the early 650s, or only a few decades before the translation of the *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*, contains for example the following instructions:

If there is a sick child of twenty years old or younger, make a spell-cord of five-colored twine with fifty-four knots. Grind cow bezoar as ink and copy (*chao*) this spell onto a piece of silk. Wrap [the silk] within the spell cord and tie it to the nape of the sick child's neck.⁶⁹

This prescription recalls the monk of the *Wish-Fulfilling* incantation's scripture who was saved from the tortures of hell when a compassionate Buddhist tied the incantation to his neck. Taken with the other evidence, the passage offers a further example of the continuities and innovations that characterized this amulet tradition, here illustrated by the (quite literal) tying together of incantation cord and inscribed spell. Furthermore, two amulets found in Chinese tombs might offer yet more important evidence in this regard. One, dating to 927 and found in a tomb in Shijiawan, to the east of Luoyang, seems to have been tied to the neck of the corpse—no doubt that of the layman named Xu Yin, to whom the print was inscribed in its colophon.⁷⁰ The other, discovered in a tomb near the Tang capital of Chang'an, inscribed to a layman surnamed Wu and dating perhaps to the eighth century, was found in a device that may have been a kind of necklace as well.⁷¹ The tombs preserve what seem to be relatively late versions of these instruments of practice: not strings binding enchanted seeds or inscribed silks, but copper and silver cases bearing spells encased and protected within them. Objects in the older styles would have been far more fragile against the corruptions of time; if Chinese corpses were adorned with them they would likely not have survived. At the moment we cannot know if they ever existed in China in those contexts, whether in tombs or otherwise. But taken together, the textual accounts and the archeological discoveries, in both their clear basic resemblances and stark differences, offer beguiling objects for historical analysis.

DHĀRAṆĪ AMULETS FROM GILGIT, KHOTAN,
AND LANDS TO THE WEST

Examples of textual charms found in Gandhāra, nearby in Gilgit, and in much more distant Khotan present suggestive evidence for the kinds of textual amulets, including those featuring dhāraṇīs, that were in use on the roads and in the kingdoms to the west of China. Indeed, if we expand for a moment the relevant field to include all textual amulets rolled and placed in capsules that were either carried or worn on the body, the Chinese tombs appear to have been part of a very broad landscape of practice, indeed. As scholars such as Don C. Skemer and Roy Kotansky have demonstrated, textual amulets have been discovered in such forms in sites located “in every corner of the Roman Empire,”⁷² as well as in Egyptian sites dating to the Byzantine periods, in Iranian sites from the sixth and seventh centuries CE, in Arabic materials of a similar age, among many other areas.⁷³ The material containers of some of these textual amulets, and the ways they were worn, bear striking resemblances to Chinese examples, in particular to the capsules that seem to have been worn as pendants. Talismanic texts that were folded, rolled, then slipped into leather pouches or capsules, or into metal tubes, and then worn around the neck as pendants, have been found in a number of sites, including sixth- and seventh-century examples written in Eastern Syriac from Iran and others in Greek from Byzantine Egypt with elements drawing on Christian, Gnostic, and pagan sources.⁷⁴

Returning to regions closer to China, the Gandhāran examples, some of which date to the fourth century CE, consist of small rolls or “twists” of birch bark inscribed with texts such as prayers and the *ye dharmā* “creed”⁷⁵ whose uses, though they remain difficult to determine for certain, scholars such as Richard Salomon have connected with dhāraṇī amulets.⁷⁶ Birch bark was one of the surfaces most often mentioned in texts calling for the inscribing of spells, whether for use as relics or as amulets, in texts going back at least to the middle centuries of the first millennium CE. Indeed, as Salomon notes, “It is clear that birch bark texts were used as amulets, in both Buddhist and Hindu practice, for many centuries.” He cites, for a very late example of this practice, the observations of G. Bühler, published in 1877: “[The] use of birch-bark for writing still survives in India, though the fact is little known. Mantras, which are worn as amulets, are written on pieces of Bhūrja [that is, birch]. . . . The custom prevails in Bengal, as well as in Gujarāt.”⁷⁷ As noted, Salomon emphasizes the difficulties in being sure about the functions of the small birch bark texts found in Gandhāra, but connects them implicitly with amulets. Given the wide spread of amulet practices in the greater South, Central, and East

Asian regions, the depictions we have of Gandhāran versions of these practices, and the seemingly perfect amenability of the bark-inscribed texts for such purposes, it would seem safe to follow him in seeing this connection here and to consider these manuscripts within the larger family of religious practices that included those of *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*.

The Gilgit examples are much more obviously related to it. Small slips of paper handwritten with dhāraṇīs that Oskar von Hinüber has called “protective charms” (*Schutzzauber*), they are particularly relevant for this study, since at least one of them bore the text of a dhāraṇī labeled the “*Mahāpratisarā*.”⁷⁸ These manuscripts are important as well because the texts of many of the dhāraṇīs, including the *Mahāpratisarā* example, contain inserted within them the names of the individuals (usually kings) whom the spells were to protect—as I will discuss in detail later, this feature is also found within dhāraṇī manuals in use in China.

The Khotanese amulet texts that have been discovered take a greater range of forms, from dhāraṇīs in Sanskrit to brief prayers or statements in Khotanese. An example of a dhāraṇī amulet contained in this material—actually, what seems to have been a model for the creation of such amulets included within a manuscript collection of brief and apparently unrelated texts—contains a version of the refrain common to its kind: using the Khotanese version of “dhāraṇī,” the text promises benefits to “he who holds the *dāraṇī* of endurance [firmly] and recites it.”⁷⁹ Though recitation of the spell seems, clearly, to be the main way the text enjoins one to enact it, the text’s injunction to “hold the dhāraṇī” seems to refer not to the more abstract or spiritualized “grasp” or “absorption” of its text and powers seen in some accounts of dhāraṇīs (i.e., in the phrase *shouchi*) but the literal taking in hand of the medium the spell was inscribed upon while reciting it. Skjærvo’s addition of the modifier “firmly” in brackets would seem to signal his agreement on this point. Evidence for other Khotanese amulets provide clearer evidence of their natures. One, another amulet model, consists of a rather cryptic assertion of protection in a cursive Middle Khotanese script that recalls certain Chinese genres of magico-religious charm. Skjærvo translates it as follows:

. . . we shall not make *them weak.
 We shall not make him sick.
 Where
 this protection may be found
 of (= from) bhūtas and kalabutanas,
 there for seven leagues
 the dominion!⁸⁰

Most of the evidence we have for particular amulets, *fu*-talismans, and seals comes in the form of models for their creation found in manuscripts and in received editions collected in canons. Thus—as in the case of the “*dhāraṇī-fu*” discussed in the previous chapter and the *Mahāpratisarā* amulets discussed in this one—when we have what appears to be an actual example of an amulet it is precious indeed. The object known both as “CA Khot 10” and “Kha. i 50” seems to be another example. It is a strip of paper containing line drawings on one side of four human-looking figures in four different poses.⁸¹ On the top is the lower half of a figure, possibly *Vaiśravaṇa*, truncated when the sheet was torn, in recognizably Central Asian attire. His boot-shod feet are held in the hands of a reclining, or perhaps flying, figure wearing only a wrap around his waist and (perhaps) a necklace. Beneath these obviously divine figures kneel two men, clearly human and apparently naked, their hands in attitudes of supplication or prayer. On the reverse of the sheet is a short text identifying it as a protective amulet. Prods Oktor Skjærvo and Roland Emmerick, in their translations of the text, read this text quite differently. Emmerick, in his 1968 article “Some Khotanese Inscriptions on Objets D’Art,” translates it as follows: “*Sūrade* (be my) protection at all times, by night and by day.” Comparing this sentence with another similar one, he finds *Sūrade* to have been one among a set of “patrons of painters and scribes, who claimed their protection.”⁸² Skjærvo, in his 2002 survey of Khotanese manuscripts, takes “*Surade*,” instead, to have been the name of the amulet’s bearer. “May [this] protective amulet of *Surade*’s protect him all the time, by night [and] by day.”⁸³ Without needing to attempt a judgment on whose rendering is correct, we can simply note the presence of an amulet featuring, like the Chinese examples of those of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*, the juxtaposition of text and image (perhaps, like on some of the Chinese amulets, images of bearer and deity), and, if Skjærvo is correct, the inclusion of the name of the charm’s bearer.

THE AMULET SHEETS

The pendants and armlets were made and worn within a tremendously resonant and far-reaching tradition. Indeed, from a certain perspective, they were the single most important part of the tradition of *dhāraṇī* amulet practice in medieval China; after all, these rings, whether simple or ornate, were at least in practical contexts all that people would have seen of the incantations in their forms as periapts. The dazzling sheets rolled within them, intricately adorned with text and image, were invisible, perhaps in some cases even

forgotten. However, even setting aside their visual splendor, the sheets are, naturally, crucial to any study of the amulets and to their incantations. If the rings help answer the question “How were the incantations worn?” the sheets provide evidence to answer equally central questions such as “How were they written down?” and “What were the sociocultural situations in which that writing occurred?”

The *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment* is explicit in its own answers to the first question. Dhāraṇī sutras typically give clear instructions for setting up the ritual spaces in which their incantations are to be chanted. Such spaces, often named *maṇḍalas*, drawing on ancient pre-Buddhist Indic ritual traditions, involve careful demarcation of the boundaries of the space, sometimes by driving spikes into the ground at its corners and using them to rope off the sides—often using cords described in the same ways as the “incantation cords” surveyed before—and sometimes by other means. The internal ground was cleansed by digging out any impurities and structured by setting out various ritual implements, including bottles of water, butter lamps, flowers, and other objects, in the prescribed manner. The *Scripture* describes its own version of these altars in the following way:

Great Brahmā then said to the World-Honored One, “If one wants to copy out this spirit incantation, what is the rite?” The Buddha told Great Brahmā, “One should secure an altar. At the four corners of the altar set out bottles filled with fragrant water. Within the altar draw two lotuses, or three, or four, or five. Around the four sides of the altar make an awn of lotus blossoms. Make a single large open lotus flower, and suspend from its stalk a band of silk. Further, make an eight-petaled lotus flower. Upon each petal make one three-forked *ji* halberd. Suspend from it a band of silk. Make another eight-petaled lotus flower. Within the center of that flower make a vajra-club, with another club upon each of the petals. Suspend from it a band of silk. Further, make another eight-petaled lotus flower. Upon each of its petals make a *yue* hatchet. Further, make another lotus flower. Within its center make a knife; from its stalk also suspend a band of silk. Further, draw a sword. Upon the point of the sword make a lotus; from its stalk also suspend a band of silk. Make another lotus flower; within its center draw a conch shell. Further, make another lotus flower and within its center draw a lasso. Further, make another lotus blossom and within its center draw a burning pearl. Burn incense and scatter flowers; make offerings of food, drink, and fruit of

various kinds. If you are copying it out in order to wear the incantation, you should make an altar of this kind according to the rite. Other altar methods are not acceptable; they are mutually incoherent [*bu de; xiang za*]. Have the one who would copy the incantation first bathe clean and put on new clean clothes. Have him eat the three kinds of white food: cream, rice porridge, and rice. Do not ask whether one should use pure paper, bamboo, silk, or other kinds of objects. All are acceptable for use in copying incantations.⁸⁴

The text then describes a number of different ways to compose the *dhāraṇī* sheets, depending on the person for whom they were to be made and the situations that faced them. Baosiwei's text lists fifteen different incantation and image configurations for, as I see it, fourteen different situations (the text gives two different sheets for women seeking to become pregnant).

1. If there is a woman who seeks a male child, then one should use cow bezoar to write it. On the silk surface, first write the incantation out towards the four corners. Inside [the incantation] draw a child adorned with jeweled necklaces. Raised at the level of his throat, [the child] should hold a golden bowl filled with precious gems. Further, in each of the four corners draw a child wearing armor. Also make various kinds of seals.⁸⁵

2. If a wheel-turning king is to wear it, then within the center of the incantation make the forms of the Bodhisattva Guanshiyin and Śakra. Above them make various kinds of Buddha seals—all the good spiritual seals should be completely provided. Further, in the four corners make the Four Heavenly Kings, with treasure adornments appropriate to each direction.

3. If a monk is to wear it, then in the center of the incantation draw a single Diamond Spirit adorned with jewels. Below him make a monk kneeling in the *hu*-style with his palms together. The Diamond One has his hand upon the top of the head of the monk.

4. If a Brahmin is to wear it, then in the center of the incantation make a Great God of Sovereignty (*Maheśvara*).

5. If a Kṣatriya is to wear it, then in the center of the incantation make a *Maheśvara*.

6. If a Vaiśya is to wear it, then in the center of the incantation make a King *Vaiśravaṇa* God.

7. If a Śūdra is to wear it, then in the center of the incantation make a kinnara god.

8. If a male child is to wear it, then in the center of the incantation make a kumāra god.⁸⁶

9. If a female child is to wear it, then in the center of the incantation make a Prajāpati. In the plans for [different] wearers described above, all the gods and spirits depicted within the center of the incantation should have youthful forms and joyful visages.

10. A woman who wishes to become pregnant should make a Mahākāla spirit within the incantation, its face black in color.

11. If it is to be suspended from a tall pillar (*chuang*) then the tall pillar should be erected at a high place. A fiery pearl should be placed at the head of the pillar and within it this spirit-incantation should be secured. All evil obstructions that exist and all sicknesses will without exception be eliminated.

12. If there is a drought make a nine-headed dragon within the center of the incantation. If there is lingering excessive rain then also make this dragon. Secure it within waters where dragons are. If there is a drought then it will rain; if there is excessive rain then the skies will clear.

13. If a merchant is to wear the incantation, then make the form of a merchant leader within the center of the incantation. Those merchants they take [under their command] will all attain ease and joy.

14. If the one who holds this incantation wears it for the sake of pleasure, then make a goddess within the center of the incantation, and also make within it the stars, the sun, and the moon.

15. If an ordinary person (*fanren*) is to wear it, simply copy out the spell and wear it.⁸⁷

SUBSTANCES OF THE SPELLS

Though ritual manuals typically claimed that any surface was suitable for the writing of spells, they tended to be much stricter about the nature of the “ink” to be employed. The *Scripture* only mentions one substance, “ox yellow” (*niuhuang*, Skt. *gorocanā*), a term referring usually to ox bezoar but sometimes, and especially in medieval China, to hardened formations from the animal’s bile duct.⁸⁸ Ox yellow was in fact one of the most commonly prescribed medicinal/magical substances in *dhāraṇī* manuals; it was to be smeared on the body, on incantation cords, or enchanted directly on its own or when mixed with other potent substances.⁸⁹ *Gorocanā*, furthermore, is one of the central ingredients in the *tilaka*, a mark made on the forehead in Indic cultures.⁹⁰ It was (and remains)

one of the most prized drugs of traditional pharmacopeias. Edward Schafer noted that “[among] the drugs of animal origin none had more repute in China than the bezoar.”⁹¹ Tao Hongjing, a central figure in the early Daoist tradition, observed around the year 500 that “cow’s bezoar was the most highly prized and costly of all medicines.”⁹² The best Chinese bezoars, which were valued in lands as distant as Persia, were thought to come from what are today the provinces of Shandong and Sichuan.⁹³ The use of bezoar in Daoism and other native Chinese traditions was also prominent, particularly in seal rites. The association with these techniques was especially close: As Strickmann notes, “there is no doubt that, early on, seals were identified metaphorically with the wonder-working bezoar.”⁹⁴

In terms simply of their material substances, written spells were often indistinguishable from many of the other objects that, as discussed in the previous chapter, were to be worn on the body (or smeared upon it, in ways not unlike those in which incantations were to be smeared-spoken onto the body). Just as one was to wear drugs such as bezoar for their efficacies, and to enchant them as doubly potent media of spell application, just so was one to use them to make material incantations. Realgar was another of the most commonly called-for substances in the writing of *dhāraṇīs*, as well as one of the most popular substances to enchant in other forms of *dhāraṇī* and Tantric ritual, at least in Chinese versions of their texts.⁹⁵ The connections that were obtained between worn spells and the sorts of mineral and vegetal amulets long popular in China, then, were not merely semiotic or discursive: on a basic material level they were often *precisely the same things*—at least as they were described in the normative texts. One could wear a bit of enchanted realgar as a periapt, or one could wear an incantation drawn with (and thus consisting of) realgar for the same purposes. Just as seals and certain drugs were closely related in native Chinese religious practice, *dhāraṇīs* and those same drugs—again, at least as their practices were described in texts—were at times very close indeed. The idea that Buddhist texts, or texts connected with the religion, were sometimes written with medically efficacious substances seems at times to have achieved the status of popular legend. Jonathan Chaves, in what he describes as a “curious footnote to the study of the relationship between calligraphy and Buddhism,” noted that the Northern Song Dynasty poet Mei Yaochen (1002–1060) complained that the calligraphy decorating a certain Buddhist temple had been scraped away in so many places by people believing that its ink possessed curative properties that it “looked as if birds had pecked at it.”⁹⁶

The caveat suggested in the previous paragraph is once again crucial, for, turning away from the normative accounts of the dhāraṇī amulets and back to actual surviving examples, these alchemical substances and their traditions appear to be nowhere in evidence. The texts are simply written and/or printed in ink (though it is possible that chemical analysis of the inks used may one day find in them traces of substances such as bezoar, bile, or realgar). We have here, once again, the now familiar divide between the prescriptive manuals, which at least in the language of their translations drew heavily on ancient Chinese idioms and traditions, and the actual material traces of practice, which for the most part seem to have been structured according to other logics and dictates. Even a layman's glance at the paintings preserved on the walls of the Mogao grottoes, or the objects discovered at Famensi, readily confirms that by the eighth century Chinese artisanal and image-making traditions had attained an exquisitely high level of development. In crafting the amulet sheets, it is clear that their makers followed not the pharmacological/magical heritages of Ge Hong and the Indic dhāraṇī adepts but their own traditions.

VISUAL STRUCTURES OF THE AMULET SHEETS

The designs on the sheets tend to be concentrically displayed in three zones: an outer zone consisting of images of ritual implements, Sanskrit syllables, and/or deities; a middle range consisting of the inscribed incantation itself, whether in transliterated Chinese or in Indic script; and in the center an image either of a tableau of the empowerment of the donor/wearer, featuring a vajra-wielding deity, or a simpler image of the eight-armed bodhisattva Mahāpratisara, sometimes also including an image of the donor in a worshipful pose to its side. The arrangement can be either of concentric circles or squares.

Taken as a whole, the tableaux on the sheets appear to be diagrammatic representations of the rites of dhāraṇī incantation found in surviving ritual manuals, specifically those of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*. Their centers render the focal point of the rite—either the action of empowerment or the icon of the incantation deity; the outer borders figure the ritual setup, which takes the form in Buddhist incantation texts of both physical implements and their bodily and mental/sonic counterparts, visually represented on the amulets in the forms of *mudrās* or seed syllables; linking them we have the dhāraṇī itself. Because of this ritual imagery, scholars such as Ma Shichang have taken to calling these objects “dhāraṇī maṇḍalas” or “dhāraṇī altars.”⁹⁷ Indeed, as we will see, the visual structures of the sheets not only reflect medieval

prescriptions for the setting up of ritual spaces but they also closely mirror sketches for the creation of such physical as well as visual spaces found among the Dunhuang documents, including two that appear to have been models for the creation of amulets that make the connections between altar and amulet particularly clear.

Let us begin our examination of the visual structures and components of the sheets with their border zones. In order to understand their arrays of objects and figures, we turn once again to scriptural accounts of rites for the inscription of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment* and their descriptions of the designs of its amulets. It is immediately clear that this outer ring of imagery is not prescribed in them. The Baosiwei translation of the *Scripture* mentions only that the spell is to be written down and that an image reflecting the nature and needs of the donor is to be made in its center. Comparing that account with early surviving sheets—the “Yale,” and “Jing Sitai” sheets, for example, (figure 2.3) and (figure 2.7)—however, the scriptural basis of the images that surround the spell is revealed. Though the matches are not perfect, the surrounding images bear a close resemblance to the objects that are either to be placed physically or depicted in drawings within the actual ritual space in which the sheets were to be fashioned. Vases adorn the four corners of both sheets, likely representations of the “bottles filled with fragrant water” that are to be physically set at the four corners of the ritual space. Similarly, among the images arrayed along the sides of the sheets are weapons sporting ribbons that are no doubt pictures of the silk ribbons suspended from weapons such as knives, swords, and halberds that one is to draw upon the ground of the ritual arena. Further, the scripture’s injunction to “make [a] lotus blossom and within its center draw a burning pearl” would also seem to have been taken up by the amulets’ makers, who executed images that, as we see, seem to represent exactly such lotuses and pearls. Though, again, the three sets of images (the scripture and the two amulets) are not identical in every detail, the resemblances are striking enough to make the sheets appear to have been conscious renditions of the rite as a whole. This resemblance becomes even more interesting, and opens out further into the world of the historical creators and buyers of the sheets, when we read the parallel account from the slightly later Amoghavajra versions of these scriptural passages into the mix.

In the Baosiwei translation it is clear that the silk-adorned weapons and fiery pearls are to be drawn onto the ground of the ritual site—but the Amoghavajra version makes it equally clear that the images are to be made instead on the amulet sheets themselves. After describing a ritual space demarcated



FIGURE 2.7

Jing Sitai amulet. Eighth century? Stamped and handwritten on paper (32.3–32.7 × 28.1–28.3 cm).

by five-colored cords anchored at the four corners to spikes of *khadiraka* (acacia) wood and adorned within with flowers, fruit, and incense, the Amoghavajra text finishes with a statement echoing the Baosiwei version's assurance that any kind of writing surface suffices for the creation of the amulets.⁹⁸ The account then proceeds, as in the earlier translation, to prescriptions of specific renderings for specific donors or situations. Taking as an example a kind of donor not mentioned in the earlier translation, we note the amulet to be made for "a man who seeks sons." The amulet model that precedes this one in the text, for women seeking sons, has "jeweled mountains" at each of its four corners, a feature that seems to be included as well in the present design. "You should use turmeric to write [the spell amulet]," the account begins (the previous example was to be written with ox yellow). "That which you seek will be achieved in its entirety. To the four sides of the *zhenyan* [that is, the spell]

you should draw various kinds of seals, and further draw lotus flowers—either two or three or four or even five lotus flowers. These flowers should all be open and spread out, their eight petals set close together, their stalks bound with silk ribbons. On the flowers draw a trident;⁹⁹ on the halberds further [draw] tied ribbons of silk. Further, draw a yuefu ax, also on the lotus flowers. Further, [draw] a white lotus—upon it you should draw a sword. Also on the [white?] lotus draw a conch. The lotuses that you draw should all [float] within a treasure pool.¹⁰⁰ Since a man is to wear it, you should not draw a child [in the center of the sheet, as is done with the amulet for a woman seeking sons given just previous to this one], but instead draw the shape of a god adorned with various gems.”¹⁰¹ For the most part, this tableau provides the template for all the remaining amulets described in the text—though in the case of the sheet to be made for monarchs, its four corners feature not bejeweled mountains but the four heavenly kings, figures we indeed find adorning the xylograph Li Zhishun amulet dated to 980 found at Dunhuang and discussed earlier (figure 2.2), though in other details that sheet is unlike any described in either translation.

Again, the images to be rendered in these accounts do not match those of any surviving amulet that I am aware of, but the shift in medium from the ground of the ritual space to the amulet sheet is striking and clearly of great significance for understanding the tradition in which the sheets were made. It is difficult, however, to be sure precisely how to understand this change. Given that most of the amulets show no sign that their makers followed the Amoghavajra version of the sutra—indeed, as noted earlier, what evidence we have suggests that it was the Baosiwei version (or, more likely, elements adapted from it) that was the favored text of the artisans—it is unlikely that the shift in design was a direct result of the new version’s appearance on the scene. Instead, particularly given the other “deviations” from scriptural warrant that I will discuss later, it is far more likely that the direction of influence was the reverse of this. That is, it was the Amoghavajra version itself that reflected the visual structures of the amulet sheets then in circulation, as well as new practices of ritual icon painting, and not the other way around.

ALTARS AND AMULETS

Preparatory drawings found at Dunhuang, apparently for use in the construction of altars, both actual spaces and their visual idealizations employed in ritual practice, help both to clarify the nature of the amulet images and to place

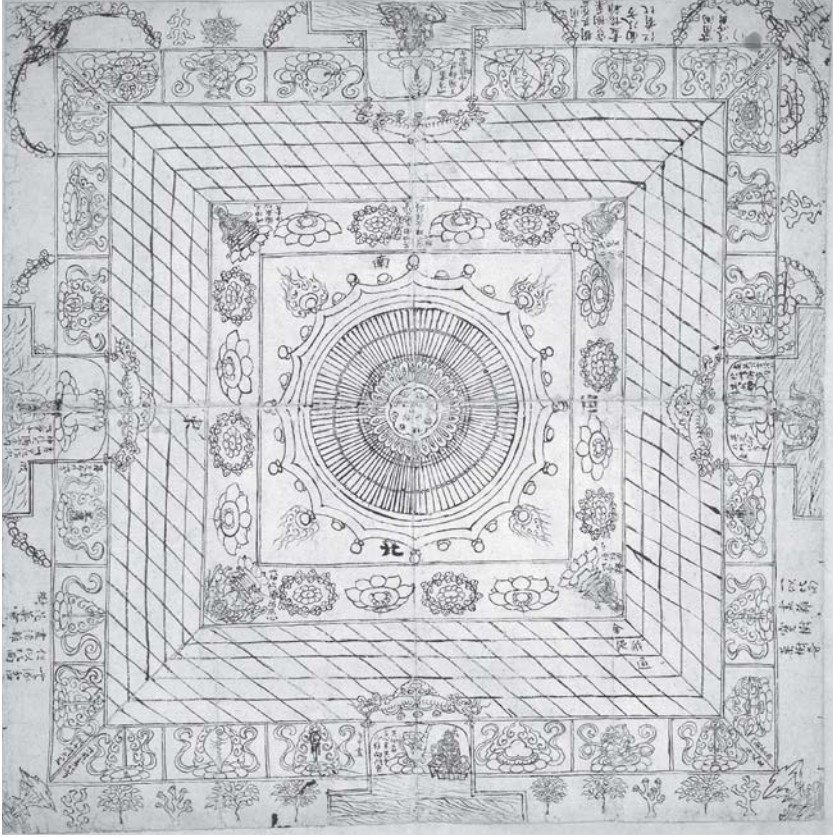


FIGURE 2.8

Altar Diagram ["Painting"], 1919,0101,0.172 (Ch. 00189). Ink and colors on paper. 58.5 × 57.5 cm. © The Trustees of the British Museum.

the sheets within wider traditions of ritual imagery and practice. Comparison with altar diagrams such as Stein Painting 172 (figure 2.8), in fact, confirms that the images on the amulet sheets belonged to the same family of ritually potent images that included the iconic altar, or *maṇḍala*, used in Buddhist incantatory rituals. This is clear not only in their general configurations—the three zones characteristic of the amulet sheets are present as well on the altar maps, though in necessarily more generalized form—but especially in the small details of their outer sections. A comparison of the border zone of Stein Painting 172 with those of the amulets reveals that many of the images—plants, fungi, weapons, gems, and wheels—are nearly identical.¹⁰² More than

this, the dynamic, even *activated*, nature of the images rendered on both Stein Painting 172 and the amulets is striking. The swords, for example, are not simply inert metal objects placed in a certain way: their coronas of flames visually suggest that these swords are active in their particular efficacies, in keeping with the ritually active nature of both types of image. The wheels, gems, and other motifs are also figured in this way. Were the diagrams simple maps for the placement of objects and images on the ground of the *daochang*, the arena in which bodily action was engaged, such visual flourishes would hardly have been necessary. Indeed, on other altar sketches such as Stein Painting 174 (figure 2.9) a map of an altar for use in the recitation of the *Incantation of Glory*, the images of lamps and water bottles were drawn much more simply. They are not aflame with ritual transformation; they are merely lamps and bottles depicted in the flatter utilitarian frame of everyday action. The incipient state of our understanding of all these images imposes the need for caution in our claims about them, yet we seem to have two different types of altars here, each with its distinctive type of map. The first type, including Stein Painting 174, apparently depicts a space to be constructed out of actual objects placed in certain ways on the ground or the floor of a temple or other sacred space. The second type, including Stein Painting 172, is composed of far more intricate images whose components are anything but simple. Stein Painting 172 seems, in fact, to be a drawing of a drawing: a sacred image of the sort indicated by the term *maṇḍala* in its later usage in the Esoteric Buddhist tradition, where the “altar” space is not to be physically entered—does not structure the physical performance of a rite—but is instead an image offering blessings and divine presence. Altars of this second type are potent objects rather than fields of human ritual action.¹⁰³

The close relationship between the Dunhuang altar diagrams and the amulets is clear in the instructions found in the two Chinese versions of the *Scripture*. It is clearest in the case of the Amoghavajra version, which (as noted) instructs its reader to draw an altar on the surface of his amulet sheet rather than on the ground. But the iconic nature of the altar is suggested as well in the more influential Baosiwei version by the absence of instructions in the text to enter the altar space physically. If we consider Stein Painting 172 as a representation of the kind of altar alluded to in the Baosiwei text, the iconic nature of the sutra’s altar becomes even more apparent—for the image on the diagram also provides no space for the practitioner. Thus, it could hardly be the image of a space for actual ritual activity, such as those described in many other ritual manuals. Some *dhāraṇī* manuals, in fact, enjoin the practitioners

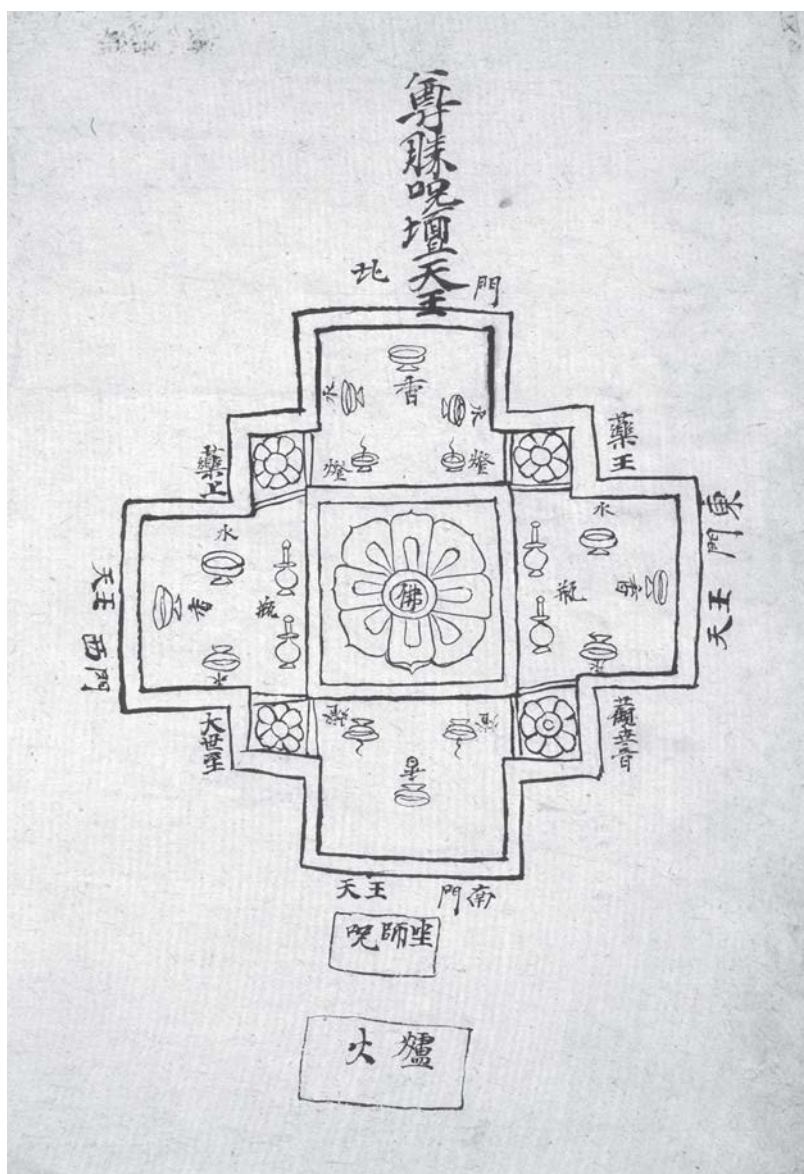


FIGURE 2.9

Altar for the recitation of the Zunsheng zhou (Incantation of Glory). ["Painting / Mandala"]. 1919,0101,0.174 (Ch.00186). Tenth century. Ink and colors on paper, 39.9 × 17 cm.
© The Trustees of the British Museum.

to copy out the spells to the sides of altars.¹⁰⁴ Renderings like Stein Painting 172, in this regard, appear to have been intended to be placed to the side of the spots where ritual actions, such as the inscription of a *dhāraṇī*, were to occur.

Sarah E. Fraser has suggested that the employment of the verb *to use* (*yong*) rather than *to draw/paint* (*hua*) in the corrections made to the details of Stein Painting 172 indicates that the images were not to be painted or drawn but to be rendered using sand in the manner of the “sand *maṇḍalas*” common in Tibetan Buddhism today.¹⁰⁵ This is indeed very likely, though the material used was more likely the substance known in a range of ritual texts simply as “powder” (*fen*).¹⁰⁶ The diagram would seem, in fact, to be the earliest material evidence in China for the “powder altars” that had been in use in Buddhist ritual since at least the middle of the fifth century, and in Śaivite and other Indic ritual traditions before that. Such altar forms seem to have come especially into vogue in China during the tenth century—the age, most likely, when Stein Painting 172 was executed.¹⁰⁷

Most importantly for our purposes, the iconic nature of the altar mandala to be rendered near the *dhāraṇī* practitioner suggests that altars and amulets were in key ways—functionally as well as visually—identical. Once a *tan* (“altar”) comes to be conceived as an iconic representation of a ritual space rather than as an actual space in which a practitioner enacted a ritual, the efficacies of its presence on the ground beside one are clearly very much like those of its presence on one’s arm, or tucked within one’s sleeve. Distinctions between amulets and altars collapse in that particular ritual frame wherein sign and signified are one: an image of a sacred space is the sacred space, with all its attendant potencies; an image tucked in a ring or a *vajra* coruscating with blessings is none other than the very thing it depicts.

TRANSITIONS IN AMULETS AND AMULET CRAFT

Returning to the amulets, we come next to the Indic syllables of the spell itself, whether transliterated into Chinese characters or rendered (with varying skill) in Indic script in the intermediary zone of the sheets. Like the amulet sheets taken as wholes, the texts of the incantations fall into two stylistic groups: earlier and later. In the early style examples—again, manuscripts and half-xylographs—the spells and central images often take a personalized character, featuring the names of the donors who wore them and the imagery of personal empowerment; in the later style examples, which are all xylographs, the incantations are almost never personalized, images of personal

empowerment rarely occur, and (interestingly, since they more often quote the *Scripture*) the central images pertain to iconographical traditions quite different from those evidenced in either extant Chinese version of the *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*.

This shift in the format of the amulets seems in part the result of a shift in the techniques of their production. Whereas the older examples carried forward a trans-Asian tradition of Buddhist incantation amulets, later versions, fully xylographic, were shaped in key ways by local versions of later traditions, including those of Esoteric Buddhism (particularly its systematic practices of eidetic contemplation) and the maturing Chinese craft of woodblock printing (which seems to have absorbed certain elements of Chinese Buddhist painting practice). This transition saw the loss of the widely-evidenced custom of personalizing the potencies of the spells themselves, and of designing the images and texts entirely as blessings for the specific individuals who were to wear them. With the transition to full block printing, the names of the donors were, in keeping with the conventions of most of the other Chinese merit-making images of the age, relegated to colophons located at the lateral or bottom margins of the sheets, away from the main action of the incantation. Coincident with this marginalization of the donor was a shift in the iconography of the central images away from those inspired by the *Scripture* to images of the multiarmed forms of the Bodhisattva of Wish Fulfillment (*Suīqiu pusa*) then spreading across Buddhist Asia, as sculptures, as paintings, and as descriptions in ritual and iconographic manuals for visualization practice.

MANUSCRIPTS AND HALF-MANUSCRIPTS

A striking difference between amulets of the earlier style and those of the later style is the presence in the former of bearers' names within the incantations. We encounter names such as Madame Wei, "Iron-head" Jiao, Jing Sitai, Xingsi, Chen Chouding, and "A-luo" written into blanks left in the texts of the incantations.¹⁰⁸ This feature, which is part of the *dhāraṇīs* as they are found in their scripture, reflects wider Indic *dhāraṇī* amulet culture; it points, once again, to a trans-Asian set of practices extending well into China. The modern Taishō edition of the Baosiwei translation includes two different versions of the *dhāraṇīs*, one based on the Koryō edition and another on the Ming edition. The great disparities between the two sets of incantations extend to the number of times the spells call for the insertion of the name of the intended beneficiary within them. Though some scholars have argued that the insertion of

the donor's name within the dhāraṇī he or she wore was a Chinese innovation based on native traditions—the inclusion of the names of ritual beneficiaries within religious texts having long been common in China—this was not the case.¹⁰⁹ The version of “your name here” included in the incantations clearly drew on Indic conventions and was reflected elsewhere in Indic and Central Asian practice.¹¹⁰ In a feature common to Chinese versions of dhāraṇīs, the relevant passage in both versions of the Sanskrit text of the *Mahāpratisarā* spell contains an explanatory note in Chinese. The texts read, “Meme (moujia) xie:” “mama (that is, ‘I’) copy.”¹¹¹ Though, as noted, scriptural versions of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment* seem to call for the writing of the name within the spell, the only glosses we have on the meaning of the spell emphasize that, as in the *Incantation of Glory*, the name was to be verbalized along with the rest of the incantation. The Heian period monk Myōkaku's (b. 1056) eleventh-century glosses on the Amoghavajra edition of the spell, the *Dazūigu darani kanchū*, or *Collative Commentary on the Dhāraṇī of Wish Fulfillment*, translate/explain the passage in this way. After an incantatory passage that asks for the capture and destruction of all who hate, the spell proceeds with an interlinear gloss, given here in parentheses: “‘Protect! Protect me!’ (That is, the bearer: at this point call out your own name or the name of another, or say ‘all beings,’ or run them together: ‘me and all beings’).”¹¹² These glosses, clearly, were made for those chanting the spell, rather than wearing it as an incantation, but they give a valuable sense of how the spell was understood as a text.¹¹³

The Koryō version of the text of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfilment*—which the Taishō editors (as a matter of general practice) took to be standard—calls for the name to be included nine times in the main incantation and once within the ancillary spell known as the *Guānding zhou*, the “Spell of Consecration.” The Ming edition calls for eight insertions within the main dhāraṇī and one each within the *Guānding zhou* and the *Yiqie foxin zhou*, the “Spell of All Buddha Minds.” There is evidence that neither edition of the *Incantation* was fully normative in late medieval China, at least in the Dunhuang region—examples found at Mogao, including a model for the creation of *Mahāpratisarā* amulets, contain versions that combine features of those found within the Koryō and Ming editions. Of the six amulets containing names within their dhāraṇīs, the two that seem to be the earliest, the “Madame Wei” and “Jing Sitai” sheets, both include nine examples of their bearers' names. The monk Xingsi's amulet (Pelliot no. 3982) also contains nine instances of his name, which is inscribed “the disciple Xingsi (dizi Xingsi). The copyist, however, missed one opportunity to insert the name within the main “root” spell, which would bring the total

number to ten, nine within the “Root Spell” and one within the “Spell of Consecration,” numbers matching the Koryō edition (though there are variations from that version elsewhere on the manuscript). Given its tattered state, the number of names included on the “Iron-head Jiao” amulet—which, recall, was hand painted (thus seeming early) but which contains an image of the eight-armed deity with the image of Jiao figured to its side as worshipper rather than as direct object of blessings (thus, as we will see later in this chapter, seeming late)—is impossible to determine. The “A-Luo” sheet, an apparently late xylograph that harks back to earlier amulet conventions, contains only five instances of its bearer’s name, a number that doesn’t match any received edition of the dhāraṇī. Chen Chouding’s amulet (Pelliot no. 3679), a singular example in many ways, appears to contain at least two short spells, including a version of the “Spell of Consecration” in which his name is inscribed. Instead of saying that he “copied it” (*xie*), however, it states that Chen “receives and keeps” or “bears” it (*shouchi*), a statement echoed four times around the perimeter of the spiraling spell by the statement “the disciple Chen Shouding wholeheartedly bears [this amulet]” (*dizi Chen Chouding yixin shouchi*).

The two Dunhuang manuscript amulets are worth considering in more detail here. They are composed entirely of incantations surrounding a simple central image, with no representations of ritual implements, buddhas, or seed syllables, such as are found on all other known examples. Chen Chouding’s amulet is smaller than most other examples. It was inscribed on a sheet of paper of light beige color, 23.6 × 24.6 cm, and had clearly at one time been folded (figure 2.10). It is unique among known amulets for the holes punched into it, which the Pelliot Catalog describes as showing possible traces of stitching.¹¹⁴ The holes at either side of the unfolded sheet line up, indicating that they had been punched when the sheet was folded. If it had indeed been sewn at one time, it is possible that Chen wore the amulet folded and stitched into his clothing—a method otherwise unattested in the material record. The amulet is unique in other respects as well. It was inscribed upon its sheet half in black ink and half in red, in a progressively loosening spiral outward from the center. Its central image, too, is not found on other known amulets: the Chinese character *an*, the standard Sinitic transcription of the mantric syllable *oṃ*, placed at the heart of an eight-petaled lotus. Though this is not a feature (as far as I can tell) of *Mahāpratisarā* conventions in medieval China, an understanding of the nature of the *Incantation of Glory* elaborated in an eighth-century commentary may shed light here. That spell is said to be in effect an emanation of its first incantatory syllable, *oṃ*, described as a burst of radiance and sound—the

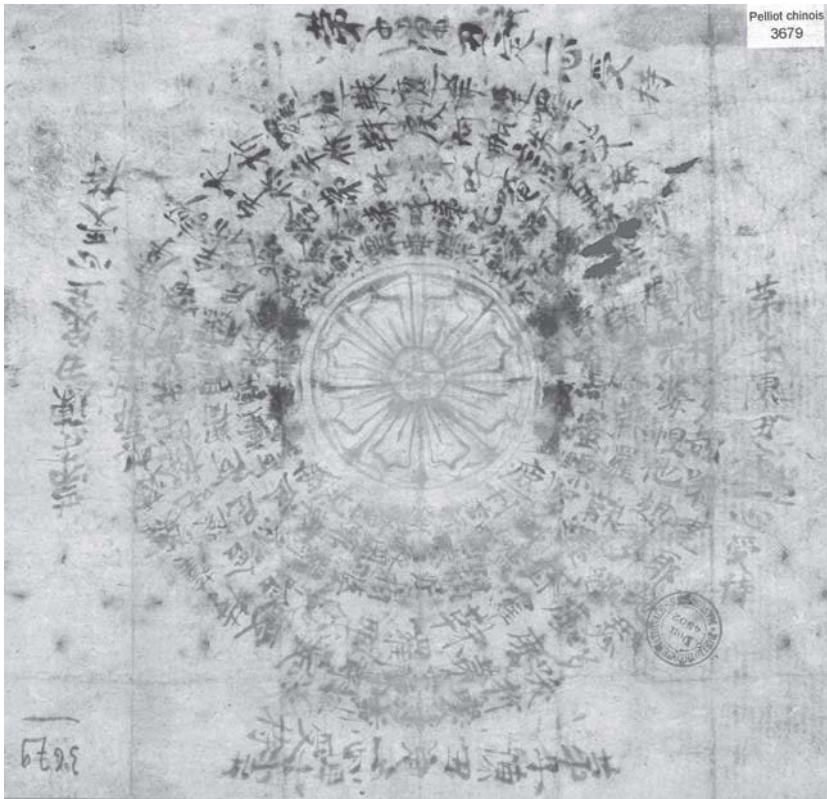


FIGURE 2.10

Chen Chouding amulet. Pelliot Chinois 3679. Tenth century? Ink and colors on paper. 23.6 × 24.6 cm. © Bibliothèque Nationale de France.

rest of the spell is said to simultaneously recount and enact the transformative efficacy of that initial burst.¹¹⁵ The syllables on Chen's amulet clearly belong to those of the *Mahāpratisarā* set, but an overall incantatory figure similar to those of the *Incantation of Glory* may have been intended, though without any corresponding textual affirmation this remains speculation.

The monk Xingsi's amulet is also made up almost entirely of text—incantations following an introduction and brief ritual invocation—figured around a simple image at its heart (figure 2.11). It is relatively large, at 44.5 × 44.3 cm, and composed of two sheets mounted together.¹¹⁶ The introduction and spells—consisting of all those listed in the Baosiwei translation—are arrayed in four triangular ranges centering on an image painted in color: an eight-petaled lotus surrounded by a square structure, with forms resembling (perhaps) leaves of

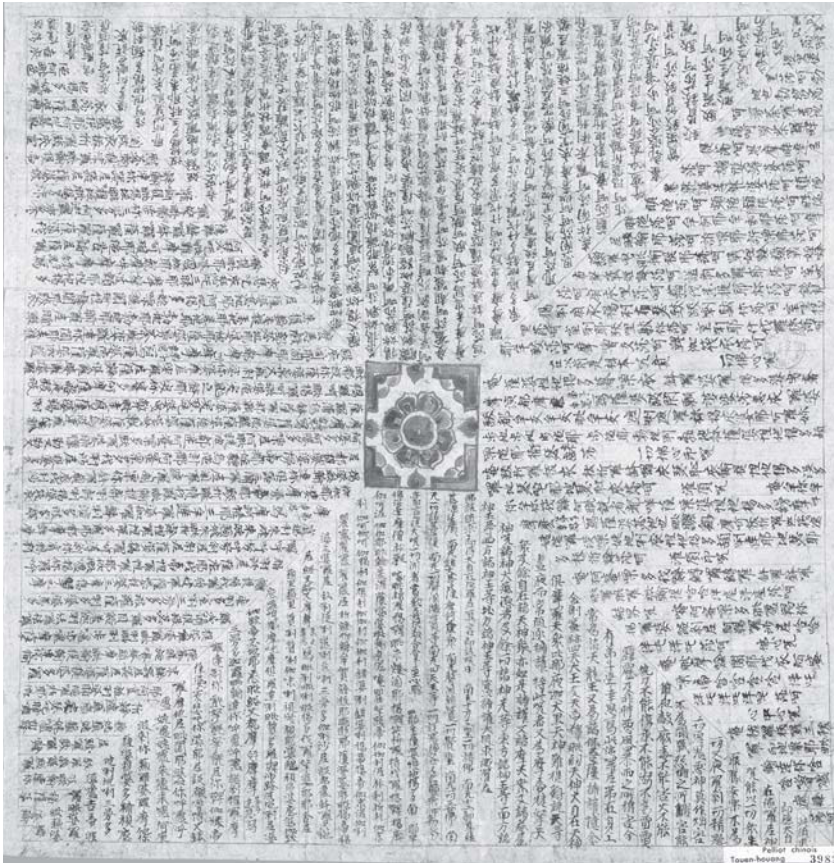


FIGURE 2.11

Xingsi amulet. Pelliot Chinois 3982. Tenth century? Ink and colors on paper, mounted on mousseline. 44.5 × 44.3 cm. © Bibliothèque Nationale de France.

the *bodhi* tree pointing inward at the cardinal points and floriate designs at the corners. The central image resembles those of architectural structures found at the tops of the ceilings of certain Mogao caves, which in turn were depictions of architectural features of temples. The triangular ranges containing the spell on the manuscript, which point inward to this quasi-architectural center, seen in this way take on the aspect of a four-sided ceiling angled inwards and upward toward the lotus blossom at its peak. The direction in which the spell was inscribed adds to this impression. Rather than starting from the center and moving outward, as the incantations of most other amulets do, the vertical lines of spell text begin at the bottom right corner of one range and proceed

leftward, expanding progressively upward until peaking in the six lines that reach the central square, then shrinking again until reaching the far left corner of that range. The text picks up again in the adjacent range and follows the same pattern. According to the architectural logic of the image, rather than beginning at the central peak and emanating downward, the spell begins close to the ground, the human level, and moves upward.

Jing Sitai's amulet sheet, dated to the middle of the eighth century, is also of particular interest in regard to the ways his name appears within the incantation (figure 2.7).¹¹⁷ Unlike the hand-drawn central image and the ritual objects drawn at the periphery of the sheet, these syllables were either block printed or stamped—the latter more likely given the uneven distribution of ink—in four sections. Spaces on the block or stamp were left blank, suggesting a sophisticated amulet “business” capable of considerable flexibility in the production of sheets, and probably high output as well. As An Jiayao and Feng Xiaotang, the scholars who have most thoroughly analyzed the sheet, observed, the calligrapher who inscribed Jing's name does not seem to have been very skilled, certainly not at the same level as the makers of the sheet as a whole. The character *tai* in his name, for example, was written quite unsystematically, taking five different forms in the ten instances of the name (the tenth being the large inscription at the side of the sheet).¹¹⁸ Here we may have hints of a tripartite division of labor: those who made the stamps (whose high level of ability, as evidenced by this sheet, An and Feng underscore); the artists who skillfully rendered the drawings within and around the stamped spell (the stampers and free hand artists may have been the same people); and the calligrapher, who seems to have been neither a “professional” nor very highly educated. Perhaps the scribe was Jing Sitai himself and the sheet represents his autograph—a tantalizing possibility, given how precious few are the actual material remains of individuals from the eighth century. Whether it was Jing or not, in the amulet sheet we would seem to have a physical trace not only of the “medieval imagination” of mystic potency and the visual translation of ritual processes but a trace as well of the sort of economic exchange that was the lifeblood of Buddhist institutions.

An and Feng, in a move the reader of this book will understand, trace part of the historical lineage of the stamps used in the creation of the sheet to Chinese practices of magical sealing such as those found in Ge Hong's *Baopuzi*.¹¹⁹ Ma Shichang, too, noted that the uneven distribution of ink left by the blocks suggests the incantation was stamped onto the paper rather than truly block printed, a fact he further suggests might display an early stage of

printing technology.¹²⁰ Scholars such as Jean-Pierre Drège and Su Bai have also noted the important place of the amulet sheets in the early history of block printing in China, and others, especially Michel Strickmann and T. H. Barrett, have explored the close relationship between ensigillation practices and the beginnings of that history.¹²¹ But in the case of Jing Sitai's amulet sheet, close examination of the forms left by the individual printing blocks on it allows us, I think, to suggest more precise possible historical connections between this particular object and that wider history. It requires, as Barrett and others have also noted, that we look not to the Chinese cultural heartland but to the Indic cultures to its west. The practice, discussed in the previous chapter, of stamping incantations and other brief texts onto clay stupas, where they then functioned as relics, inspired the creation of high quality stone stamps, such as the example from Kashmir shown here (figure 2.12). The *dhāraṇī* on this soapstone (steatite) stamp, which has been dated to either the seventh or eighth century, was carved in reverse onto the stone in a script identified as "proto-Sarada."¹²² It has been identified as the *Bodhigarbhālāṅkāralakṣa*.¹²³ Both in its rectangular shape and in the visual character of the text carved in relief upon it, it resembles the stamps that would have been used to print each portion of the spell on Jing Sitai's amulet sheet, at least insofar as we can extrapolate such information from the impressions left by those stamps. We might speculate, then, that this stamp is a member of a family of objects that may have had a direct relationship with the stamping or crude block printing



FIGURE 2.12

Kashmiri *dhāraṇī* stamp. 1880.168. Seventh–eighth century. Steatite. 3 × 6.3 cm. © The Trustees of the British Museum.

technique used to produce the Jing Sitai sheet. We know that the Indian practice of stamping texts onto clay stupas was known in China from, at the latest, the middle of the seventh century, when Xuanzang published the account of his travels—though we should never assume that the discursive accounts of elite monks, or of scriptures for that matter, contained the earliest news of practical innovations, whether native or imported. It is very likely that, in the present case, Indic practices of dhāraṇī stamping had made their way into China before Xuanzang made his report in the imperial capital. But whatever the facts of its introduction into China, by the mid-eighth century, when Jing Sitai got his amulet, the practice had clearly been known in China for some time. Building on Strickmann's and Barrett's work, we can further note that the shape of this Kashmiri stamp and the shape of the printed impressions on Jing's sheet suggest the possibility that the printing technique evidenced there may have resulted from the adaptation of specific text-relic practices imported along the trade routes. Differences in ritual logic and doctrinal imagination aside—issues likely of little interest to artisans whose business was the improvement of their methods—specific techniques of producing incantations as relics and as talismans closely connected those two styles of Buddhist spell craft. But whether or not this particular Chinese technical innovation did in fact come to pass in this way, inspired by imported instruments, South and Central Asian practical connections are evident not only in the forms the spells took on the early group of sheets but in the names inserted within the texts of the incantations. As we have seen, examples of dhāraṇī charms from Gilgit, now northern Pakistan, display precisely the same forms of name insertion within their incantation texts, and may in many cases have been produced in similar ways.

The personalized dhāraṇī charms from China and Gilgit were, however, quite different in other ways. The Gilgit charms, which seem to date to the first half of the seventh century, are simple slips of paper shorn of imagery, bearing only the text of a spell and the name of the intended target of its protective influence; whereas, as we have seen, the Chinese examples are multi-layered hybrids of text and image. The sociological locations of the two sets of charms also differed: surviving Gilgit examples were all made for royalty, while (at least so far) the Chinese amulets that have been found belonged to men and women of humbler station. There is, however, evidence of an exception to this trend within the Chinese evidence, one that suggests that a member of the imperial house wore a dhāraṇī amulet at least once. In 758 (*Qianyuan* 1), in the midst of the chaos of An Lushan's (d. 757) and Shi Siming's (d. 761)

rebellion against Tang rule, Amoghavajra, translator of the second Chinese version of the *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*, made a gift to the Tang emperor Suzong (711–762; r. 756–762) of “one text of the Great Dhāraṇī of Wish Fulfillment, written in Sanskrit” (*Fanshu Dasuiqiu tuoluoni yiben*). Though it might initially seem that this gift consisted of the Sanskrit text of the *Scripture* itself, perhaps the one whose translation Amoghavajra would himself oversee, we next read that Amoghavajra urged the emperor, in by now very familiar terms, to “think on this seal and wear it at your belt” (*nian jian er dai zhi*), promising that benefits to his turbulent reign would result.¹²⁴ This detail, clearly, reveals the manuscript to have been an amulet sheet of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*.¹²⁵

The Gilgit charms and the early set of Chinese amulets point once again to a common culture of dhāraṇī amulet practice that traveled the trade and pilgrimage routes from the northern reaches of Indic culture, in Gandhāra and Gilgit, through the desert oases of Khotan, Turfan, and Dunhuang, to the medieval Chinese cultural centers of Chengdu, Chang’an, and Luoyang, and on to the eastern shores of the Asian continent. The presence of the practitioners’ names within the texts of spells from both Gilgit and China adds a new level of detail to this picture. Not only are general similarities in basic form revealed in the material evidence from these far-flung sites—that is, that people wore dhāraṇī periapts in all of them and probably did so in similar ways—but we can now see that at nearly the eastern and western edges of this region even small details of practice were maintained. The material record, in this way, brings to life the abstract statements of the scriptures and peoples them with historical individuals: kings of Gilgit and emperors of China engaging in the same practices as humbler, and now often nameless, Buddhists of late Tang, Five Dynasties, and early Song China.

Like the images that adorn the outer rims of the early sheets, those at their centers rarely match scriptural accounts. The early manuscripts and half-manuscripts, in their depictions of vajra-wielding gods offering blessings to their bearers, are for the most part evidence instead of adaptations made in either partial knowledge of scriptural guidelines or only partial allegiance to them. The Yale amulet, dated to the mid-eighth century, wholly hand drawn and inscribed without any printed elements, bears at its center a tableau of empowerment similar to one prescribed in the *Scripture* (figure 2.3). Dominating the scene, slightly off-center and filling its portion of the square from top to bottom, is a majestic figure seated with legs crossed on an upturned flower that, convention indicates, must be a lotus. The figure’s upright, half-naked

torso and rather feminine head are each wreathed in fiery aureolae, the latter's dark oval of fire contrasting strikingly with the lighter flames of the larger and rounder mandorla set slightly behind and below it. A faint mark on the divinity's forehead might be a third eye. A crown of jewels and (it appears) leaves adorns its head; it wears a necklace, an armlet high on its left arm, and bracelets on its wrists. Both according to scriptural accounts and in terms of the action of the scene, its hands figure the clear meaning of the tableau. In its left hand it holds a large vajra-club, marking the divinity as a "Vajra-Wielder" (*vajradhara* or *vajrapāṇi*)—clearly a representation of the "Vajra (or "Diamond") Spirit" (*jīn'gang shen*) mentioned in the *Scripture*. Its right arm is extended with hand resting just above the black hair of a kneeling woman in robes, her palms together in an attitude of devotion and supplication. This woman is, of course, Madame Wei, the bearer of the amulet. An inscription flanking the tableau reads, "Received and borne in her 63rd year; the bearer (*shouchizhe*) Madame Wei wholeheartedly makes offerings."

The presence of the "Diamond spirit," as noted, recalls the scripture's manual for the construction of amulets and the multiple configurations listed in it for a range of possible bearers and needs. However, when the image is checked against those prescriptions it becomes clear that, strictly speaking, it does not really match any of them. The two prescriptions for female bearers in the received editions of the scripture—both for women seeking to become pregnant—call either for the depiction of a child bedecked with gems or one of a black-faced Mahākāla, the "Great Black God" (*daheitian*), like Vajrapāṇi a major figure in the then-developing Esoteric tradition. The only amulet described in the *Scripture* that calls for a vajra-bearing figure is intended for monks. "If a monk is to wear it, then in the center of the incantation draw a single Diamond Spirit adorned with jewels. Below him make a monk kneeling in the *hu* [or Central Asian] style with his palms together. The Diamond One has his hand upon the top of the head of the monk."¹²⁶ This description, clearly, is very close to the image on the Yale sheet—change "monk" to "female donor" and remove the foreign style of kneeling and we have a precise account of its central image. The "Diamond One" is indeed adorned with jewels, and its right hand reaches out above the head of the one it blesses.

This iconographical near miss becomes more interesting, and is revealed as further suggestive of Tang practical traditions, when we notice that at least one and perhaps three other Tang era amulets bear strikingly similar images at their centers, all of which come slightly closer to the details of the textual description than does the image on the Yale sheet. In the case

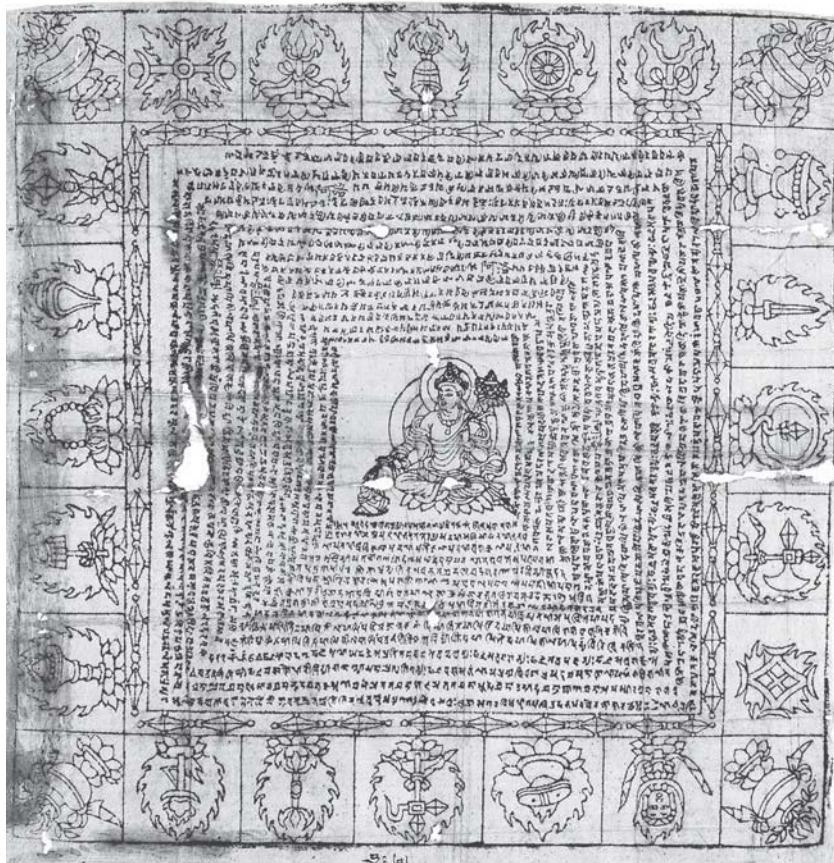


FIGURE 2.13

A-luo amulet. Tang Dynasty. Xylograph, ink and color on paper. 23.5 × 24.5 cm. After Cheng, Xi'an beilin, 153.

of one of them, the “Jing Sitai” amulet, the resemblance is especially clear, and I will focus on it. A possible second is found in the center of the “A-luo” amulet sheet (figure 2.13). The object in the hand of its seated central deity is unclear to me, though it certainly might be a stylized vajra. The possible fourth image in this group is a sheet found at the site of a metallurgy works, which, like Jing Sitai’s amulet, has been deemed partly printed with spaces within the spell (between *meme* and *xie*, as directed in the scripture) left blank for individualization. The image rendered in its central space is partly damaged—the arms of the standing robed figure, which depict the

crucial action of the scene, have been erased through wear on the image at its folds, as have the head and upper torso of the figure who kneels before it, apparently “in the *hu*-style,” which Ma has identified as female based on what can be seen of its clothing. As too little of this tableau’s crucial details can be discerned, however, I will not consider it here, other than simply to mention it; but it does seem likely that it belongs to this set of empowerment imagery.¹²⁷

In the case of the Jing Sitai amulet, hand drawn in the center of the spell stamped upon it is a tableau that, like the “A-luo” and “Metallurgy Works” sheets includes the image of a donor “kneeling in the *hu*-style,” with one knee on the ground. But, like Madame Wei, neither Jing nor A-luo were monks, as their portraits makes clear: both are shown wearing headscarves popular among Tang men,¹²⁸ and Jing has a beard. An and Feng, in their analysis of the sheet, noticed the discrepancy between the *Scripture* and this particular instrument of its enactment. They suggested that Jing, or the makers of his amulet, understood *seng*, the word for monk used in the *sūtra* translation to refer not only to monks but also to laymen.¹²⁹ As An and Feng did not offer any other instances of such construal in the historical record, however, it seems unlikely that this usefully accounts for a possible discursive source of the image. But the question of how to understand the relationship between the image and the scriptural account remains intriguing.

It is clear, however, that the appropriateness of the image of a Diamond Spirit for monks’ amulets was indeed known, at least at one time, in the region near Dunhuang. Though we should recall that no actual amulet sheets bearing this precise image have been discovered there, two models for their creation, explicitly for monks to wear (*seng dai*), are among the manuscripts discovered in the Mogao library cave (figures 2.14 and 2.15). They appear to be versions of the same diagram, the one in figure 2.14 perhaps left unfinished at an early stage of its drawing, and that in figure 2.15 more (or wholly) complete. Taking the more complete example as our focus, the manuscript known today as Stein 4690, both its prescribed central image and its incantations are (at least ultimately) traceable to the Baosiwei translation of the *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment*. The rest of the manuscript, as with all known amulets, seems to have been an improvisation based on local conventions.

The model centers on an eight-petaled flower set within two concentric circles, a form that overall resembles the “lotus platforms” upon which images of buddhas and bodhisattvas sit or stand. In the center of the flower,

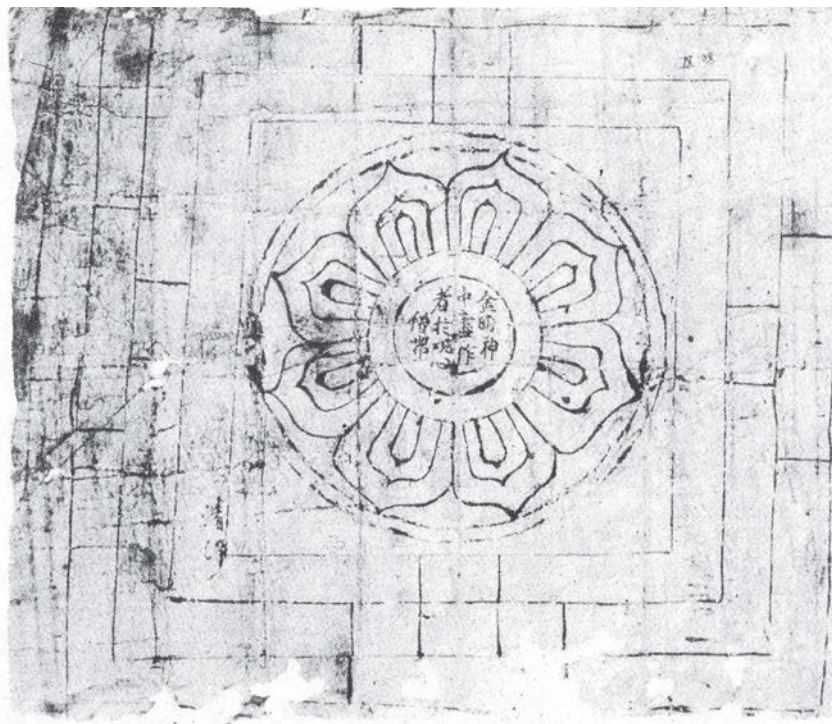


FIGURE 2.14

Amulet model (unfinished). Tang Dynasty? Ink on paper, 31.5 × 37. © The British Library Board (Or.8210/S.6264).

reading vertically and from left to right, a text states, “[For] monks to wear: within the incantation make one Diamond Spirit.” If we take “make one” (or, “make only one,” *jinzuo yi*) to be an error for the Scripture’s “draw one” (*huazuo yi*)—the crucial characters being quite similar—then the two texts match perfectly, though the amulet model leaves off the rest of the description of the deity as well as the instructions to draw a monk “kneeling in hu-style with palms together, the Diamond One’s hand pressing down on his head.”¹³⁰ The spells, which are inscribed in Chinese script in two rows in square formation around the central image, match spells included in the Scripture. Interestingly, they include not the main incantation or any of those that are to be personalized with their beneficiary’s name but a group of four ancillary spells that do not: the “Spell of the Consecratory Seal” (*guandingyin zhou*), the “Spell that Establishes the Ritual Space” (*jiejie zhou*), the “Spell of

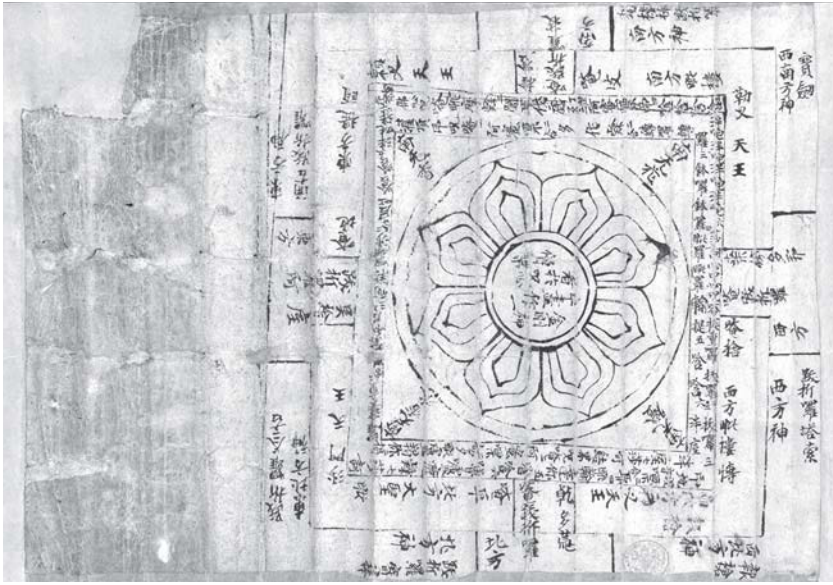


FIGURE 2.15

Amulet model. Tang Dynasty? Ink on paper. 30.5 × 39.9 cm. © The British Library Board (Or.8210/S.4690).

the Buddha Mind” (*foxin zhou*), and the “Spell of the Mind Within the Mind” (or, perhaps, the “heart of the heart,” “essence of the essence,” or “spell within the spell”; *xinzhongxin zhou*).¹³¹ The texts of the incantations begin in the inner row at the southeast corner of the diagram and spiral clockwise onto the outer row, ending in the northeast corner. (If we take the text describing the inner image as orienting the diagram’s ideal reader, the sheet was designed to have the western side at the top.) The first two spells make up the inner row, the second ending once again at the southeast corner. That the designers intended this is suggested by the fact that the final character extends to the end of (in fact, slightly beyond) the frame described by the two rows, which makes the outer row appear to extend the inner in the manner of a spiral. The third spell begins there; it and the fourth travel three-quarters of the distance around the central square. The remainder of the manuscript consists of brief spells, often featuring the word *vajra* (*bazheluo*)—the “diamond” (*jin’gang*) of the central deity’s name—and the names of deities of the directions arranged systematically. These include generalized figures such as “the God of the Southeastern Direction,” etc., as well as the famous spirits

of the four directions known as the Four Heavenly Kings. Just beyond the central image, at the intercardinal corners, are four invocations: “Veneration to incense!” (*nanwu xiang*), at the southeast position; “Veneration to blossoms!” (*nanwu hua*), at the southwest; “Veneration to lamps!” (*nanwu deng*), at the northwest; and “Veneration to scented water!” (*nanwu xiangshui*), at the northeast. These invocations clearly perform crucial functions in the amulet’s basic nature as a ritually active image of a ceremonial space.

A final example of a manuscript amulet, also from Dunhuang but in many respects unique, shows that the amulets were used for more than purely personal empowerments. Known today as EO 1182, it is the only early style amulet I am aware of that features at its center an image other than an adaptation of the *Scripture*’s account of the amulet for monks.¹³² It is a silk sheet, whose central image depicts a fierce deity brandishing a club, no doubt a vajra, striking a vital standing pose, with one foot on a raised lotus platform, before two kneeling figures—perhaps a mother and her son. It seems in fact to be a rendering of the amulet for women seeking sons, which the *Scripture* says should feature an image of the god Kumāra, here transliterated as *Jumoluo tian*. This deity is often called the Diamond Lad (*Jin’gang tongzi*), or *Vajrakumāra*, the name he is given in a range of *dharma* and Esoteric sources. The incantation just beyond this tableau is quite crudely inscribed, the seeming jumble of its arrangement made worse by the fact that it is sandwiched between an inner circle and an outer square (as far as I know, the only sheet with this combination). The spells do not match those of the *Scripture*, as far as I can determine; unlike other amulets, as well, the incantatory space contains the syllable *om* (*an*) inscribed at each of the four intercardinal points around the inner circle, a fact suggesting that, despite the appearance of a jumble, the inscription was executed after some planning. The remainder of the surface space is made up of sections containing a wide array of images, some of which match those described in the *Scripture* and found on other amulets—tridents and vajras sporting ribbons resting on lotus blossoms, etc.—and others that do not. These include swastikas (one with an eye within each interior quadrant) and images of buddhas, bodhisattvas (including multiheaded figures), and holy men of various kinds (*siddhas*?). The amulet is hard to date or place, either in the picture I have given here or in the chronology of the other amulets, but the fact that it was hand drawn and inscribed on silk and contains a central image not found outside the *Scripture* suggests that it was made at an early date, outside the mainstream of the production of the amulets or perhaps before its conventions had taken hold.

XYLOGRAPHS, EPISODES, AND ICONS

The absence of names inserted within the spells of all but one of the full xylographs marks them as quite different sorts of objects from those of the earlier group.¹³³ These sheets do often contain personalizing features, but they reflect practices then popular in China—of appending colophons or inserting cartouches with names and dates and adding images of worshipful donors—rather than those of the Indic amulet traditions that I have surveyed. Further, the new central images and the place of the donors within them helped to transform the character of the sheets from “episodic” to “iconic,” the latter indicating here a species of religious image that by the ninth century had become standard in Chinese Buddhist paintings and prints, and whose conventions were parallel with developments within the then-burgeoning tradition of Esoteric Buddhism. These shifts in style, in part byproducts of the rise of the new iconography and its place in contemplative rather than amuletic practices, seem as well to have been abetted by the shift to full block printing and the subsuming of the amulets within image conventions familiar to its artisans. Now included on the sheets were colophons containing not only the names of the donors but at times those of the printers as well, and sometimes not only the date of the initial block carving but that of individual printings. New, too, were quotations (or seeming quotations) from the spell’s scripture that make explicit the powers of the amulet and how they are to be engaged, an element reflecting, among other things, the cartouches on hanging silk icons of longstanding popularity, and those of the newer genre of printed votive icons, all of which would have been well known to the xylographers.

The inclusion of the colophons and cartouches and the absence of the inserted names—along with the shift in central iconography from an image of the empowerment of the donor to an iconic image of a deity—stripped the amulets of their formerly personal character, including their continuities with broader Asian amulet traditions, and transformed them into rather standard Chinese Buddhist images to whose potent physical presences the names and dates (and sometimes the images) of mortal Buddhists were merely attached, no longer the direct objects of their blessings. In this, perhaps tellingly, they resemble the basic formats of the *dhāraṇī* pillars of the *Incantation of Glory* whose specific stone forms (when constructed primarily as media for incantations) seem to have been wholly Chinese creations without any known specific Indic models. Like those of all but one of the xylograph amulets, the pillars’ makers ignored the injunctions of ritual practice

to include the names of the targets of the spells within their texts and added them within colophons beneath the incantations.¹³⁴ The later-style amulets in this way joined the pillars—and dhāraṇī inscription more generally—in becoming normalized according to the conventions of Chinese Buddhist icons and inscriptions.

Though in general terms their structures are identical with the earlier manuscripts—all remain structured by three zones the contents of which, when reduced to their basics (ancillary images, spell, central image), remained the same—their details make clear that the xylographs were very different kinds of objects. Though both kinds of images qualify as “iconic,” as I used the term earlier in this chapter to indicate the ritually active nature of certain images, here a further distinction must be made. No longer in themselves enactments of ritual action (in this case that of empowerment) the prints were shaped according to logics of *contemplation* and *prayer*, which had become normal in the Buddhist imagery of the age. In reshaping the amulets in this way, following in part the dictates of the new multiarmed iconography, the xylographers brought the images into line with the logic and conventions of most of the other painted and printed Buddhist images of the ninth and tenth centuries, which, like the new style of the printed amulets, figured deities in the iconic mode, with donors depicted to their sides, and included the wishes of the donors and purposes of the images and makers in colophons, whether to the side of the images or in cartouches within them.

The basic categorical distinction between “episode” and “icon” delineated (in different ways and using different terms) by Wu Hung, Stephen F. Teiser, and Victor Mair in their studies of Chinese images, though not perfectly applicable here, proves very useful in understanding the shifts in practice and imagination figured in the later sheets. The specific terms of the dyad “episode” versus “icon” are Wu Hung’s,¹³⁵ who divides the issue partly in terms of whether the design of an image is “self-contained” in its logic (episodes) or whether it assumes “a direct relationship between the icon and the viewer.”¹³⁶ One might object that, in the case of amulets sealed within armlets or other carrying cases (or sewn into clothing), all of the sheets were, in a very literal sense, “self contained” and none could reasonably be thought to have had any kind of relationship with viewers, direct or otherwise. In terms of the reception of the amulets, this was certainly the case; however, my purpose in this section is to explore not their reception but the sources and logics of their making and conception. Considered in this way, concepts such as “icon” remain useful, however the icons were employed. In fact, the concepts—and

especially, in the case of the icons, as Teiser's analysis makes clear, their typical Buddhist examples¹³⁷—help to clarify the ways that the new designs of the amulets entailed an essential shift in their character and in the ways the dhāraṇīs inscribed upon them and their cult were imagined.

In episodic images, as Wu Hung describes them, “the significance of the representation is realized in its own pictorial context. In contrast to an iconic representation, the viewer is a witness, not a participant.”¹³⁸ In the case of the amulet sheets that figure episodes of the empowerment of their bearers—both in text and image—we can take the first of these statements in the strongest possible sense: not only is the “significance” of the depiction realized, the very action it depicts is carried out. The empowerment of Jing Sitai through his amulet, for example, is not merely a scene in a narrative of empowerment whose telling we witness; according to the ritual logic of material incantation, we are witness to *the actual event itself*.¹³⁹ With the later iconic images of the multiarmed deity, the image is there for the viewer to venerate in the manner seen in some cases in the accompanying image of the donor. The viewer, there by happenstance, and the pictured donor are both in this sense “participants” in the activity figured by these sheets. But here lies the difference between the earlier and later amulet sheets: in the later examples this participation is indirect, contingent, and inessential to the basic fact of revealed divinity, the icon itself. Though depictions of worship are sometimes described in texts accompanying paintings as being in themselves “eternal” and meritorious enactments of ritual, clear distinctions in intensity and in kind must be drawn between the ritual actions figured in the two sets of images. Veneration is a central and powerful ritual action in Buddhism, but it is one that situates its actors at a distance, in another order of reality, from the divinity worshipped. Empowerment sites its human object directly within the stream of blessings and divine power. Thus, the dhāraṇī episodes are self-contained, of a piece, while the icons figure a divide that those on the human side (our side) cannot truly bridge.

The spells inscribed on the two kinds of sheets, in this way as well, figure very different sorts of presences. The spells of the empowerment images envelop the human traces within them, nourishing them like fish within a stream; mortal life partakes of their power. The incantations surrounding the icons, however, are in themselves icons to be venerated, extensions of the majesty of the central divinity. Dhāraṇīs, when they are spoken in sutras, often become part of the light said to circle the buddhas who speak them, emanating out from them in this way until they fill the cosmos. Such images of spiraling incantatory light were likely part of what the xylographers



FIGURE 2.16

Amitayus amulet. Stein Painting 247 (Ch.00152). Tang Dynasty. Xylograph, ink on paper. 12.9 × 16.2. © The Trustees of the British Museum.

intended to evoke by the wheels of syllables that surround the central figure in many of the most visually (and technically) sophisticated amulet prints. It seems, indeed, to have been part of the allusive content of the square-formed spells, too. A printed dhāraṇī amulet, Stein Painting 247, closely related to those of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment* but featuring instead an image and incantation of the Buddha Amitāyus (Wuliangshou), makes clear the connection between spell and light (and, as well, between luminous spell and consecration) (figure 2.16). The simple and apparently mass-produced xylograph, approximately 13 × 16 cm, features an image of Amitāyus surrounded by an incantation in spiraling square formation with a colophon alongside it that equates its spell with the “consecratory radiance” (*guanding guang*) of the eye of the Buddha, here personified as the deity “Mother of the Buddha Eye.” “This great vow of the [Buddha of] Limitless Longevity vastly accords with prayers: what is prayed for in the mind will certainly come to pass. The supreme and auspicious consecratory light of the Mother of the Buddha Eye can eliminate

the evil paths of rebirth The spot where these mystic words are placed will be protected and held by dragons and demons. The body of the one who wears these śarī-gāthā [that is, “reliquary verses”] of the Law at his belt will be the same as all the buddhas. . . . ”¹⁴⁰

The circular forms of spell texts on *Suīqiu* amulets (and it must be emphasized that sheets bearing them are in the minority, perhaps due to the relative technical difficulty of producing them) resonate with a family of iconic visual structures central to contemplative forms of *dhāraṇī* practice, a family deriving from the circular objects of contemplation and visualization known as “moon discs” (*yuelun*) that includes “syllable wheels” (*zìlun*), “incantation wheels” (*zhoulun*), and “*dhāraṇī* wheels” (*tuoluoni lun*). These various “wheels” (or “discs” or “circles,” depending on the context) were employed in a range of contemplative practices in *dhāraṇī* and early Esoteric rites, most of which in their most basic forms involve the imagination of a disc, likened to a full moon, upon which syllables, either alone or in series, are made to appear. Though in the more elaborate practices of later Esoteric traditions these visualizations can be very elaborate indeed, in their earlier forms, dating to the age of the *Mahāpratisarā Sūtra*, they were much simpler. A passage from the later Bodhiruci version of the *Amoghapāśa*, an incantation whose close relation with the *Mahāpratisarā* we have already seen, should make clear enough for the purposes of this chapter the connection of these objects of active imagination to the middle structuring ranges of the amulets. In the midst of imagining the visual form of the Buddha *Mahāvairocana*, one perceives (*guan*) above the deity’s heart (a standard site for the visual imagination of the discs) a “great moon disc, brilliant and utterly pure. At its round edge are arrayed a hundred shimmering syllables (*zì*) of burning gold, each moving along [the edge of the disc].”¹⁴¹ This spinning wheel of syllables then becomes the site of more elaborate perceptions/imaginings, but the basic form of the wheel and its characters—which in many cases are explicitly said to be those of incantations—makes clear, I think, the connection with the amulets. The prints made to be worn as amulets, with cousins of the incantation wheels figured upon them, were not, it is worth restating, used in contemplative or other ritual practices of active veneration (at least such were not the uses for which they seem to have been constructed).¹⁴² Nevertheless, the iconic character of their visual forms, which we now see included their inscribed spells as much as their central deities and their larger mandalic structures, were products of a religious culture that emphasized the potent ritual presence and often the devotional contemplation of the visual forms of

deities. This culture, particularly its manifestations within Esoteric Buddhist circles, exerted a strong shaping influence on the new styles of amulets and on those who made them.

We see this shaping influence most dramatically in the case of a *Mahāpratisarā* sheet, dated to 1001, that was discovered not in an amuletic context—not, that is, within an armlet or other carrying case—but within a reliquary stupa. Indeed, though the print bears a close resemblance to amulet sheets, it seems to have been intended not as an amulet but as an object to be used in devotional rites. The incantation of this print, given in Chinese script and printed in the form of a centrifugal spiral emanating outward from the buddha, begins with the text of an invocation that is evidenced among the Dunhuang materials, one that seems to have been chanted within ritual practices centering on the worship of the Bodhisattva of Wish Fulfillment.¹⁴³ Neither this sheet nor the other print it was found paired with appears to have been intended as text relics. Both seem instead to have served a function ancillary (perhaps offering protection or enhancement) to relics, given that they were found folded and rolled around nine relic grains inserted within a *chuang* pillar-shaped section of a votive reliquary contained within a large stupa.¹⁴⁴

Both xylographs are in key ways different from any other yet discovered. Neither features images of either the empowerment tableaux of the early style amulets or the eight-armed bodhisattva of those of the later style. The second sheet, dated to 1005, contains an image of the Buddha Tejaprabhā, a figure closely associated with stellar deities in this period—and, indeed, his image on the print is in this vein. The 1001 print features a more conventional image of a buddha at its center, probably Mahāvairocana. As noted, they seem not to have been intended for use as relics, yet neither were they created as amulets to be worn on the body. Both appear instead to have been made as aids to devotional practice, in ritual contexts quite different from those I focus on in this chapter. Though for this reason I consider these two prints for the most part beyond the scope of this study, we might cautiously take them as examples of what the sheets became after their amuletic uses fell out of favor (no amulet sheets postdating the Ruiguangsi prints have yet been found).¹⁴⁵

Taken in this light, the two Ruiguangsi prints—and the example dated to 1001, especially—seem to exemplify both a more advanced stage in the movement toward iconic/contemplative logics and a deeper stage of absorption within the ritual worlds of high Esoteric Buddhism. The shift in the character of

the amulets from episodic and intimately personal to iconic appears in part to have been related to a larger shift in the history of Buddhist incantation practice from the diffuse styles of what Arthur Waley called “Dhāraṇī Buddhism” to the much more systematic world of the high Esoteric lineages. Though the older styles clearly remained a vibrant loose tradition through at least the tenth century—the Dunhuang evidence is clear in this regard—the more recently arrived “Esoteric synthesis” exerted a powerful cultural pull soon after its arrival, in contexts ranging from the imperial court to print shops out toward the periphery.¹⁴⁶ Given that all the amulets, both early and late, were—quite obviously—parts of dhāraṇī practice in medieval China, it is only natural that this larger historical transformation was manifested upon their inscribed faces. Yet, the Ruiguangsi prints aside, our evidence for the uses of those amulets never points directly to Esoteric ritual milieus but instead to personal practice—usually of laymen—and to tombs, the nameless occupant of the Jin River tomb, for example. The Dunhuang evidence is harder to gauge, for nearly all evidence for the uses of those amulets was lost when the prints were added to the general store of texts and images hidden there.¹⁴⁷

The iconography of the xylographs—both the central deity and the peripheral supporting cast—shows progressively greater signs of the influence of contemplative ritual practice: the mantric syllables on lotus blossoms, a prototypical image of eidetic contemplation, in particular. But the presence within the text of the print dated 1001 of the invocation of the incantation’s deity, a text that as we will see was clearly a product of an Esoteric milieu, is the strongest evidence yet of the influence on the amulet makers of high Esoteric ritual practice, a fact that is especially clear when taken together with the non-amuletic intentions of the designers.

The non-amuletic character of the two sheets is clear. The colophon accompanying the text in Indic script on the 1005 print features not the practice of wearing the spell but that of inserting it into *chuang*, a term referring originally to tubular or octagonal banners but by the Tang also indicating stone pillars in that form—the latter being, of course, the very sort in which both prints were found. Like the colophons on earlier amulet prints, it does cite and adapt the claims of the scripture; it simply focuses on different claims and prescriptions. Though as always it is difficult to infer intentions from their products, the fact that the *chuang* practice is featured most centrally in the text (not to mention that it was, in fact, found within a miniature *chuang*) seems a solid basis for taking the designers at their word and seeing in this print a kind of object very different from the earlier amulets.¹⁴⁸

The root print bearing the spell in Chinese script makes its particular ritual context clear. The invocation, which precedes a version of the spell attributed to the later Amoghavajra edition (something that in itself sets the sheet apart and signals its ritual milieu), makes no mention at all of wearing the inscribed spell on the body for simple protection and blessings. Instead, it locates the spell and the print as a whole within the high tradition of Esoteric Buddhist mandala practice.

We invoke the Saint of the Lotus Blossom Womb, the infinite and pure portal of the encompassing grasp [dhāraṇī], whose all-pervading radiance illumines the world, whose fiery garland appears in response to the three-thousand-fold cosmos. The Mind-According Jeweled Seal appears from the mind; the invincible¹⁴⁹ lord, the great incantatory king, who is ever within the three mysteries of the Thus-Come One. He is victorious in yoga, vowing to attain the stage of awakening. Lord Vairocana preaches and Vajrapāṇi receives the marvelous words of reality [zhenyan; the incantation]. Compassion arouses the mystic words that embrace all beings. Cultivate the *siddhis* and the methods of success [sādhana]: fully conceive within the mind a moon disc appearing; quiescent in samādhi, contemplate the root lord . . .¹⁵⁰

The language of the high Esoteric tradition is clear here, particularly in the imagery of the Lotus Womb Realm, an alternate name for the Womb Realm Mandala (taizang jìe; Garbhadhātu)—one of the two basic subsystems of the tradition in East Asia—whose central “root lord” is Mahāvairocana, the buddha figured at the center of the print. As well, the language of *siddhī*, the “perfections” of Esoteric practice, *sadhāna*, the general term for the rites in which these perfections are enacted, and *yoga*, one of the most common names for the tradition as found in its Chinese texts, mark the text as a product of Esoteric ritual conventions. Marked in this way, in fact, the iconic visual structure of the print itself connects with Esoteric practice. Icons of deities, as objects first to make and then to venerate, are often central components in surviving ritual manuals from the Tang tradition, where they are described as surrounded by images from ritual practice—water jars, vajras, jeweled wheels, etc.—that recall those found on the amulets and altar models. In addition to the amulets and the Ruiguangsi prints themselves, there is evidence that such Esoteric ritual icons were produced in print shops, perhaps the very same ones in which late-style amulets were made. The Dunhuang xylograph held in Paris known

as EO 1232, an iconic representation of the Thousand-Armed Guanyin surrounded by his retinue and framed by vajras and, at the corners, wheels, bears a strong if general resemblance to accounts found in ritual manuals for the rendering of icons for veneration and contemplation.¹⁵¹

As usual, however, the Esoteric sources do not tell the whole story. The amulets, and the Ruiguangsi prints, bear a feature that is neither called for in ritual prescriptions nor found on the printed icon of the Thousand-Armed Guanyin that resembles them so closely: colophons and images of donors. When looking for possible sources of these conventions, particularly within the Dunhuang cache, evidence is near to hand, for these elements were found on a great range of painted and printed religious images found there. Painted icons on silk (often bearing the images and names of their donors or intended beneficiaries) and block-printed versions (mass produced without individualizing features and containing instructions for their proper worship) bear just as crucial a relation here as do the contemplative icons of the monastic altars. We must recall, once again, that the amulets found in contexts of actual practice were found in tombs of laymen that contained no other signs of Buddhist practice; they were not at all features of high ritual. Images from outside the Esoteric lineages further clarify the nature, and, no doubt, contemporary sources for the execution of, our iconic amulets.

The evidence provided by the Dunhuang collections suggests, in fact, that deity icons were among the most popular forms of portable Buddhist imagery in the ninth and tenth centuries. In common with amulet sheets that center images of the eight-armed deity, such images feature representations of divinities, typically either buddhas or bodhisattvas depicted in full frontal posture whose presence and radiating divinity are the focus of the image as a whole. In the case of silk paintings, they often include an accompanying image of their donor(s) as well as texts ancillary to the image that explain its nature or the facts surrounding its creation (or both). For an example let us take a typical icon of Guanyin from the Stein Collection of Dunhuang paintings, the painting on silk known as Stein Painting 14, dated to 910, of the bodhisattva in standing posture flanked by two much smaller human figures, a deceased nun and a young man identified as the younger brother of the donor (figure 2.17). Like the xylograph dhāraṇī amulets, this painting prominently features texts of the sort common to its genre, among which is one in praise of the bodhisattva, including the stated intention that the image will “perpetually enact fulsome offerings” to him (*yongchong gongyang*) of the kind mentioned above. Other wishes include those for the peace and stability of the Tang Empire as well as a wish for the rebirth of the donor’s deceased relatives and Buddhist



FIGURE 2.17

Guanyin icon. Stein Painting 14 (Ch.liv.006). 910 CE. Painting, ink and colors on silk.
77 × 48.9 cm. © The Trustees of the British Museum.

teacher (the nun pictured) in a pure land.¹⁵² Most importantly, for a comparison with the amulets, are statements of the potency of the deity, and by extension his image, which parallel statements of the efficacy of the dhāraṇī xylographs.¹⁵³ Such statements, naturally, served to *create* the efficacy—at least in the minds of their readers—of the objects they were inscribed upon.

Portable images such as these, which had long been popular by the time of the transition to the wood block printing of amulets, appear to have provided key elements of the basic iconic template according to which the carvers of wood blocks made their images (a template that had, it would seem, been adapted in turn from still older iconic images such as those of the buddhas that lie at the centers of pure land tableaux on Dunhuang cave shrine walls). Though some notable episodic xylograph images remain from the period—the most famous being sutra illustrations (a genre that for Teiser was emblematic of the narrative mode)¹⁵⁴ such as those serving as the frontispieces of early printed editions of the *Diamond Sutra* and the *Sutra of the Dhāraṇī of Stainless Pure Radiance*, two of the earliest known printed texts in the world—most early printed Buddhist images are iconic in character.¹⁵⁵ These include a great many block printed ritual icons, some of which, though they were very different sorts of objects from the amulets, bear a basic visual resemblance to them, from the iconic deity to the accompanying texts, which sometimes included incantations. Stein Painting 237 (figure 2.18), a ritual icon that proclaims, in two rows of text to either side of the main figure, “The Great Saint Bodhisattva Mañjuśrī universally urges all to resolve to make offerings to and receive and hold [this icon],” provides a typical and clear example.¹⁵⁶ The text below the icon proper proclaims that its image figures the “true figure” (*zhenyi*) of the great deity on his adopted seat in the Wutai mountains, proper devotion to which—according, the text makes clear, to the spiritual and economic capacities of each devotee—fulfills all prayers, ultimately bestowing the “return to eternal bliss” of all sentient beings (*huishi youqing tonggui changle*). Toward this end, the text provides two incantations for its worship: “The Five Syllable Incantation of Mañjuśrī, The Bodhisattva of Child-Like Truth” (*Wenshushili tongzhen pusa wuzi zhenyan*), “a-ra-pa-ca-na,” the famous and ancient basic mantra of the Indic deity found in a great many Buddhist texts; and an otherwise unattested incantation called the “Dhāraṇī of Mañjuśrī’s Awesomely Potent Dharma Treasure Store Mind” (*Wenshushili da weide fabaozang xin*).¹⁵⁷ Xylographs such as this one would very likely have been produced within the same print shops as those amulets, for which they would have provided ready-to-hand resources for the new dhāraṇī iconography and its attendant transformations in the visual character of the amulets.



FIGURE 2.18
Mañjuśrī icon and liturgy. Stein Painting 237 (Ch.00151.b). Tenth century? Xylograph, ink and color on paper. 27.9 × 16.8 cm. © The Trustees of the British Museum.

NEW ICONOGRAPHY

Narrowing our focus from considerations of the overall visual format of the later-style iconic amulets to the particulars of their central imagery, connections with Esoteric Buddhist ritual practice and iconography once again become clear. Eight amulet sheets feature at their cores images of the bodhisattva Mahāpratisara bearing his characteristic implements in his eight arms: lariat, ax, sword, trident, wheel, book, banner, and vajra. These amulet sheets (with one possible exception) are later than those that feature the image of empowerment explored previously. They include the nearly identical ninth-century Sichuan University and Shaozhen amulets (the latter figure 2.19); the Xu Yin example, dated to 927 (figure 2.20); the Xi'an city piece; the

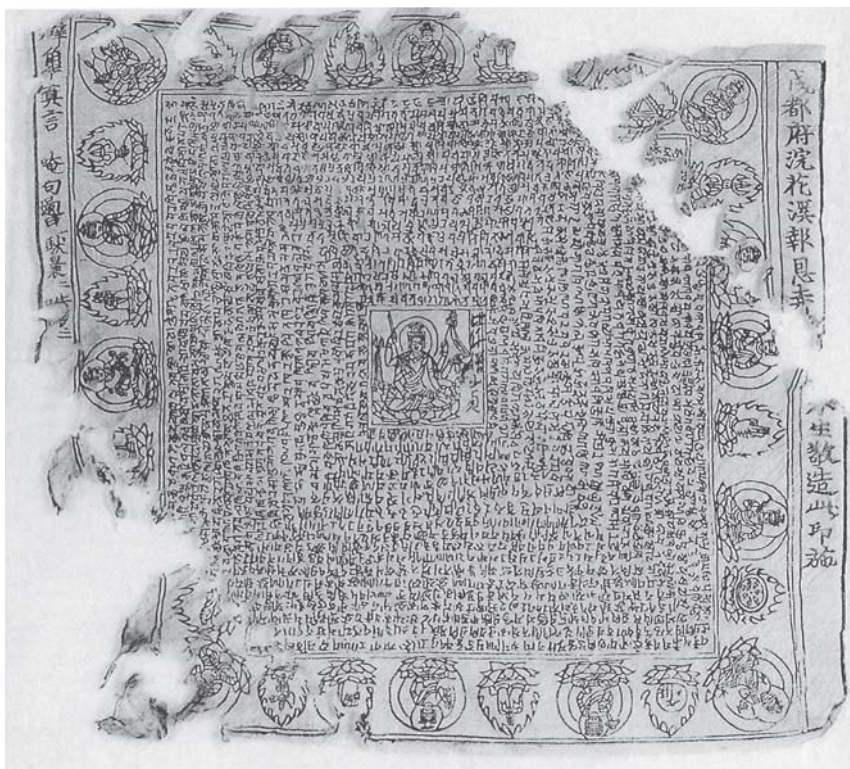


FIGURE 2.19
Shaozhen amulet. Late ninth century? Xylograph, ink and color on paper. 30 × 31 cm.
Courtesy of the Shaanxi History Museum.



FIGURE 2.20

Xu Yin amulet. 926–927 CE. Xylograph, ink and color on paper. 38 × 28.5 cm. After Drège, “Les premières impressions,” fig. 7.

Li Zhishun amulet (Stein Painting 249) (figure 2.2); and the undated Yang Fa and “Bodhi-nature” xylographs. The eighth example is Iron-head Jiao’s (figure 2.21), a singular object in several ways.¹⁵⁸ Published photographs of the sheets are not always clear enough to allow certain identification of the implements in the deities’ hands, but they all seem to follow the template that, as we will see, was found in images in India, Indonesia, and China, and which predates the four-headed form of the deity described in Esoteric scriptures beginning in the tenth century. As noted, these central images bear no relation to the prescriptions of either Chinese translation of the *Mahāpratisārā Sūtra*. They were, however, found in a range of media and contexts across Asia in this period, including (aside from those of the amulets themselves), murals, ritual manuals, and sculptures. Consideration of these images and their relationships with the amulet tradition reveals further details about the world of practice of which the amulets were part and within which they transformed. The iconography of the dhāranī bodhisattva, which appears in

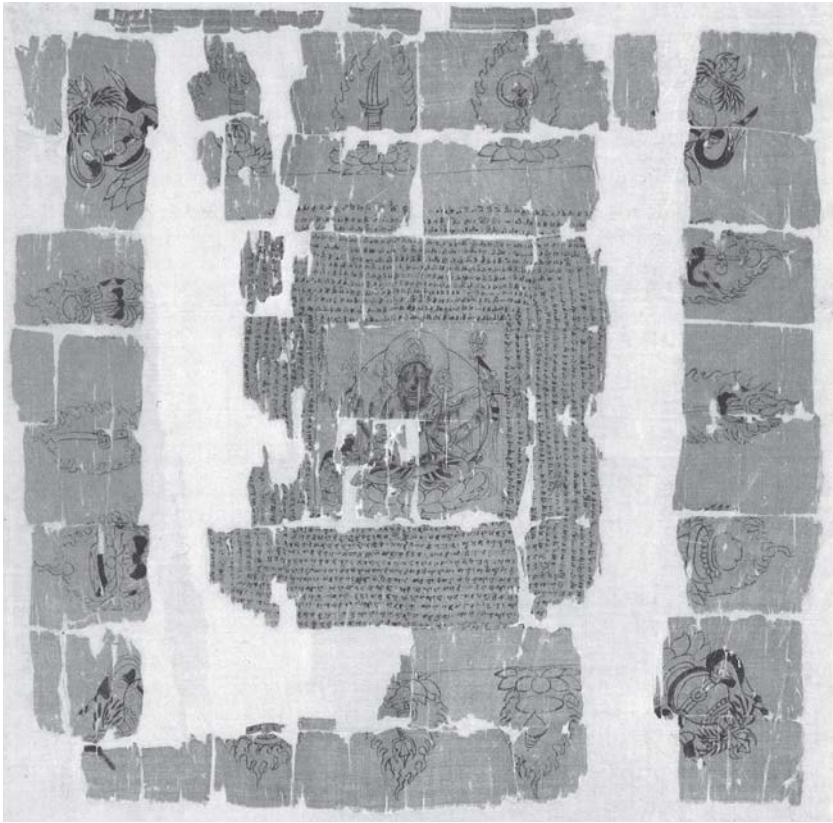


FIGURE 2.21

Jiao Tietou ["Iron-head Jiao"] amulet. Xi'an Beilin Museum. Late eighth century? Ink and color on silk. 26.5 cm × 26.5 cm. After Cheng, Xi'an Beilin, 152.

the Chinese material record not long after the early amulets and their scripturally inspired imagery of empowerment, seems originally to have constituted a separate but parallel tradition of Mahāpratisara visual culture, one (in China at least) initially found in Esoteric Buddhist circles. It appears that as the cultural power of the Esoteric ritual and iconographic traditions grew, their conventions for the imagination of the *Incantation of Wish Fulfillment* came for the designers of the amulets to replace those of the earlier scripture—even those of the translation attributed to Amoghavajra, the preeminent Esoteric ritualist of the age.

Cave 148 at Dunhuang, dated to 776, which features an iconographic program centering on multiarmed "esoteric" forms of Guanyin, contains what



FIGURE 2.22

Dasuiqiu bodhisattva from Mogao Cave 148, Dunhuang. Drawing copyright Dawn Brennan.

appears to be the earliest extant image of the Bodhisattva of Wish Fulfillment (figure 2.22). The image is located on the southern slope of the cave's ceiling, where it is the central figure in a mandalic tableau constituted by eight flanking figures: three bodhisattvas and one heavenly king to each side. Accompanying labels identified all the figures, originally, though only a few of them remain legible. The identity of the central figure, determinable already based solely on the implements in his eight hands—axe, lariat, sword, vajra, trident, book, banner, and mudra (though a wheel would be expected here)—is made much more secure by what remains of his accompanying cartouche. Of the four characters inscribed there in the late eighth century, only the first survives—*sui*—which given known possibilities (and the makeup of the image itself) can only have begun the name *Suiqiu pusa*, the Bodhisattva of Wish Fulfillment.¹⁵⁹ Based on their iconographies and the two legible cartouches, the six bodhisattvas arrayed around the central figure are *pāramitā* bodhisattvas,

figures associated with the six “perfections” of Mahāyāna practice: charity, ethics, patience, effort, meditation, and wisdom. The two legible cartouches identify the bodhisattvas of charity (bearing a bowl of fruit) and forbearance (bearing a mirror). As Liu Yongzeng has noted, these bodhisattvas, and the *Suīqiu pusa* himself, all appear in these iconographic forms within the Womb Mandala system of Esoteric Buddhism, though they are not associated there with each other in any clear way. The two heavenly kings represented in the tableau, Virūdhaka (*Bīlīulecha*) and Dhṛtarāṣṭra (*Titoulaizhai*), are also in some Esoteric systems associated with the Bodhisattva Guanyin, particularly in his thousand-armed form. Yet, once again, these relatively late Esoteric systems are only tangentially relevant to an understanding of the *Suīqiu* imagery in the cave, which was likely drawn instead from looser traditions of dhāraṇī practice. The fact that Cave 148 features three versions of Guanyin—of the Mind-According Jewel and Wheel (*Ruyilun*; *Cintāmaṇīcakra*), of the Unfailing Lariat (*Bukong juansuo*; *Amoghapāśa*), and of the Thousand Arms—is clearly crucial here, though further research will be needed to clarify the precise nature of all these connections. Dorothy Wong argues that the source of much of the Esoteric iconography of the Dunhuang caves of this period, including that of Cave 148, is Bodhiruci’s translation of the *Amoghapāśa dhāraṇī sūtra* (T no. 1092).¹⁶⁰ Such a basis in dhāraṇī practice (rather than in an Esoteric mandala system) makes sense for this period, given both the layout of this cave and the great popularity of dhāraṇī practice at Dunhuang at the time—Arthur Waley noted, after all, that the Buddhism of Dunhuang evidenced in the manuscript hoard was well characterized as “Dhāraṇī Buddhism.”¹⁶¹ The *Suīqiu* icon and its cave present fulsome and compelling images of the visual imagination of dhāraṇī practice glimpsed more narrowly on the xylographs.¹⁶²

The lineages of the formal Esoteric tradition do offer important evidence, however. The earliest textual accounts of the eight-armed bodhisattva, which date from early in the period of the amulets, are found not in Chinese translations of scriptures but in manuals from Sino-Japanese Esoteric ritual tradition, including those reported by Kūkai (774–835), once a disciple within Amoghavajra’s own ritual lineage. The xylograph amulets, taken as wholes, figure precise iconic images of ritual practice—indeed, Katherine Tsiang has observed that in this context their three registers may be taken as emblems of the three modes of activity (*sanye*), or “three mysteries” (*sanmi*), which are said in Buddhist doctrine to comprise human action, especially ritual action: “body” (the hand mudras and physical objects in the outer rim), “speech” (the incantation), and “mind” (the icon in the center, which in the case of

the eight-armed bodhisattvas was often the object of visualization and devotional practices).¹⁶³ Among the early textual traces of the presence in China of the eight-armed Bodhisattva of Wish Fulfillment is the description contained in Kūkai's *Notes on the Secret Treasury* (*Hizōki*), a text that, as Ryūichi Abé describes, "consists of one hundred fragmentary sections of [Kūkai's] handwritten record of the oral instructions he received from Huiguo," one of Amoghavajra's disciples.¹⁶⁴ Among those instructions we find the following for the depiction of the Great Bodhisattva of Wish Fulfillment within a maṇḍala: "Deep yellow in color, with eight arms. The upper left hand [holds] a golden wheel of fiery brilliance atop a lotus; in the next hand is an Indic book;¹⁶⁵ in the next a jeweled banner; and in the next a lariat. His upper right hand holds a five-pronged vajra; in the next is a halberd; in the next a jeweled sword; and in the next a hook-ax."¹⁶⁶ Kūkai's notes would seem to date to 805, the year of his teacher Huiguo's death, but this description was maintained in Japanese ritual practice for at minimum another century and a half, and in at least one text it became part of the guidelines for visualization practice. In the Shingon monk Junnyū's (890–953) *Contemplations of the Ritual Spheres of the Essential Deities* (*Yōson dōjōkan*), the practitioner is told, in the "Contemplation of the Ritual Sphere of the Great Bodhisattva of Wish Fulfillment," that in this meditation the syllable "a" transforms into an Indic book, which then transforms into the bodhisattva complete with its eight arms, each holding the items as described in the *Hizōki*.¹⁶⁷ Another Japanese manual states that the syllable can first be transformed into a vajra, which then should become a book, before becoming the bodhisattva.¹⁶⁸ The eight-armed figure does not appear in a Chinese translation of a sūtra until the tenth century—the *Foshuo yuqie dajiao wang jing*, or *Scripture of the King of the Great Teachings of Yoga*, translated by Fatian (a.k.a. Faxian, d. 1001)—and then only in a four-headed form reflecting an apparently later South Asian iconographic transmission that seems to have had no impact on East Asian developments.¹⁶⁹

Icons of the single-headed eight-limbed *Mahāpratisara*, the form present on the xylographs and in East Asia more generally, had by the ninth century been spreading across Buddhist Asia for decades, appearing in sculptural form in eastern India and central Java and as painted and printed images in Tang, Five Dynasties, and early Song China. Gerd Mevissen has suggested that surviving metal and stone statues and stone temple reliefs from India and Java may date from as early as the eighth century.¹⁷⁰ The most securely datable of these images seems to be "a large stone relief carved in the centre of the north-eastern wall of the Candi Mendut, a temple in Central Java of the late 8th or

early 9th century, about 3 km to the east of Borobudur.”¹⁷¹ Assuming that the iconography originated in India, then, an early or mid-eighth-century date for its birth seems easily possible. The details of these three-dimensional images, like those of their two-dimensional Chinese counterparts, vary within a limited range of options; while for the most part the implements carried in the deity’s hands are the same, their relative positions are often different.¹⁷² Indeed, based on Mevissen’s descriptions of twelve Indian and Javanese examples, only two of them—one from each location—may match, though wear to the sculptures, as well as the subjectivity inherent in the art of identification, makes absolute certainty in this matter impossible.¹⁷³ None of the non-Chinese images, furthermore, precisely match any of those found in China, and with the exception of the nearly identical Sichuan University and Shaozhen prints, none of the Chinese amulets matches another. Clearly, details such as the locations of the implements or the specific seated postures of the deities mattered little to the sculptors in figuring the god Mahāpratisara, or, it would seem, the ritualists associated with them.¹⁷⁴

Questions of precisely how these images spread as far as they did—as Mevissen notes, “the countries from which the images originate mark the boundaries of the Buddhist world”¹⁷⁵—and particularly the reasons for their presence in both China and Indonesia, are intriguing but rarely answerable in any detail. In surveying the evidence of the armlets and their own nearly equally wide spread, I could merely point to their far-flung traces and to the trade routes that stretched between the westernmost and easternmost of those traces. Here one can only do the same. In the present case there is, however, a legend that might (at least at first glance) help begin to offer hints about the travels of the eight-limbed deity. It involves none other than Amoghavajra and his sea journey in 741 to Buddhist lands in South and Southeast Asia, particularly the leg of that journey that brought him to Java. Given Amoghavajra’s close association with the Mahāpratisarā, as its translator and as advocate for its efficacies to the imperial court—recall the account of his gift to the emperor of a Wish Fulfilling amulet to be worn on his belt—the possibility arises that he was a key link between the two regions where the incantation was practiced and worshipped (or, perhaps, that his biographer wished to hint that he was). As the account given in Zhao Qian’s (fl. 766–774) biography of Amoghavajra relates:

When [Amoghavajra’s ship] reached the border of Kalinga (Heling) [that is, Java],¹⁷⁶ it met with a heavy storm. In his terror, each merchant

on board had recourse to his own spiritual methods [for ending the storm]—all without effect. They then bowed down together and begged the master [to save them]. Huibian, the Lesser Master, also cried out. The Great Master said to them: “I have a method. Do not worry.” Thereupon, taking up in his right hand a five-pronged “bodhi-mind” mallet [that is, a *vajra*] and in his left a volume (*jia* [= *qie*]) of the *Scripture of Prajñā* [*pāramitā*], *Mother of the Buddhas*, he extended [his arms] and performed the rite of empowerment (*zuofa jiachi*), chanting the *Wish-Fulfilling* [*Dhāraṇī*]. He chanted it but once. Huibian was astonished: The winds immediately ceased and the sea grew placid. Such was the Master’s power.¹⁷⁷

Taken on its own, this tale of the incantation’s marvels (and note that here it is an incantation, not an inscribed talisman) might be taken as suggesting a role for Amoghavajra in the transmission of the sutra, a link between these two regions of the spell’s practice.¹⁷⁸ However, any possible accuracy in the tale’s account is immediately called into question when one turns to the *Scripture of the Incantation of Wish Fulfillment* and finds a much more elaborate version of this very story. As Amoghavajra’s own translation relates:

There was a layman named Vimalaśaṅkha. His clan was large and wealthy, their coffers overflowing with silver and gold and piled high with treasure and grains. The layman was a merchant leader and traveled the seas in a great argosy collecting treasures. On the high seas a *timiñ* fish (*dimi yu*)¹⁷⁹ beset his ship and the dragon king of the seas, his eyes wide with anger, added to this by stirring up great roaring thunder and lightning and raining down adamantine hailstones. The merchants beheld this lightning and hail and were terribly afraid. They cried out for aid but none came. The merchants then approached their leader, crying out to him with sorrowful voices, “Noble sir, you must think of some plan to save us from these troubles!” At this time the mind of the merchant leader, strong with the great wisdom, was without fear. He looked upon the merchants crushed with fear and said to them, “Merchants, do not fear! Do not fear but have courage. I will help you evade these horrors.” His merchants then took heart and said to him, “Great merchant leader, we pray that you quickly tell us of your method for averting disaster and preserve our lives.” Thereupon, the merchant leader said to the merchants, “I have the Great Incantatory Kings’ famous *Dhāraṇī* of

Wish Fulfillment. It can defeat all that is hard to control with its great spiritual power and free you from this sorrow.” He then immediately wrote out this *Dhāraṇī* of Wish Fulfillment and secured it atop the mast. At this time, the *timīṇ* fish saw the ship shining brilliantly like a great flaming fire—the mighty wisdom fire of the *dhāraṇī* consumed the *timīṇ* fish.¹⁸⁰ When the dragons saw this mark (that is, the flames of wisdom), compassion arose within them and they flew down from the sky to make offerings. They caused the argosy to reach this treasured continent [where the Buddha resides].¹⁸¹

The connection with the tale of Amoghavajra’s wizardly prowess is tightened when we read in his biography that some time after he subdued the storm by chanting the spell, he encountered a “great whale” (*da jing*), which he defeated by employing a different potent text. Clearly, the author of his biography simply adapted the scriptural tale to his account of Amoghavajra’s life. The question of why he did so will likely never be answered, but, in the context of the present discussion of the spread of the *Mahāpratisara* iconography to Java and Tang China, it is very interesting that the author chose to insert this tale into the narrative just as Amoghavajra was nearing Java. Perhaps it was indeed meant to signal Amoghavajra’s relationship with the *Mahāpratisara* cult then thriving there.

The tale of Amoghavajra’s incantation of the spell connects in fascinating ways with both the iconography and the ritual invocations of the Bodhisattva of Wish Fulfillment. Recall that when Amoghavajra incants the spell against the storm, he holds a vajra in his right hand and a book in his left hand. Though Amoghavajra had only two hands to employ, his actions might be taken here to mimic the image of the spell’s deity, who as we have seen, is depicted as employing these very objects. Kūkai’s *Hizōki*, in fact, describes the deity as holding a vajra in one of his right hands and a book in one of his left—a fact that may not simply be coincidental. Furthermore, as noted earlier, ritual manuals from the Sino-Japanese Esoteric tradition say that images of the bodhisattva summoned to the mind in ritual practice should be produced as a transformation of the image of an Indic-style book, an image that, in some cases, should itself have been made from an imagined vajra. Do such details of iconography and eidetic contemplation reflect incantation practices—or those of biography—of the eighth century? I have not, so far, discovered any similar instances, but it remains a fascinating possibility. The text containing the tale dates, furthermore, to 774, the year of Amoghavajra’s death, which also

makes the passage the earliest datable trace (if trace it is) of the multiarmed iconography in China—two years before the mural in Cave 148. The late 770s may have been a particularly important era in the spell's history in China.

CONCLUSION

Returning now full circle to the Chengdu tomb that began this discussion, we have a much clearer understanding of the amulet found on the arm of the one buried there, of the wide-ranging and complex practical traditions it exemplified, and of the picture of the body and its relationship with the cosmos its use implied. That amulet and those like it, we have seen, make manifest a wide range of Buddhist practice in eighth- through tenth-century China, a range, in fact, wider and deeper than nearly any other available to the historian of late medieval Chinese Buddhism. This range extended from the impersonal—canonical prescriptions for practice that took their places on temple library shelves among a great many others, often with little to distinguish their relative importance—to the highly personal: sheets inscribed with the names of the men and woman who bore them on their bodies, often found on those bodies in their tombs, the final intimate spaces of corporeal existence and the final arenas of Buddhist practice in this world. The amulets provide, as well, vivid evidence of how transformations in religious practice in late medieval China could be driven by “external” factors such as, in this case, advances in textual production and the rise of xylography and its cultures, as well as by regional shifts in trade that closed off the traditional sources of *dhāraṇī* amulet forms to the northwest of China and opened up new sources to its south. The amulets make clear in this way that Chinese Buddhists took part in a living trans-Asian culture of practice and imagination that was continually renewed through trade, pilgrimage, and conversations with Buddhists of the wider world. These changes were not only products of the evolving logics of the ritual traditions of Esoteric Buddhism but were enacted within a far more open and wide-ranging technical culture that carried forward an ancient heritage of protective magic connecting Indic, Central Asian, and Chinese religious cultures in a complex whole.

In this chapter, aside from introducing the amulets within some of their practical contexts, I have tried to show how they were exemplars of one of the two modes of material efficacy central to Buddhist incantation practice: that is, adornment, as opposed to direct application (which is the subject of the next chapter). Both of these modes were adopted by the makers of talismanic

dhāraṇī inscriptions from ancient ritual practices of the speaking of spells; they were, in fact, among the structuring conventions of Buddhist practice writ large—the ways in which expectations about the workings of the world were enacted. Practices of the form of material incantation characterized by logics of adornment reveal expectations about the world and its spirits, its dangers, its interconnections among human, divine, and demonic spheres, and about the ways that the spiritual ornamentation of bodily persons was said to transform those persons utterly, to remake them at the level of essential substance from the fleeting imperiled stuff of humanity into the diamond-like luminosity of the truly real. Descriptions of such fundamental transmutations in the human stuff are even more vivid and explicit in accounts of the other basic mode of material efficacy, that of direct anointment or unction, to which I now turn.